

THE HAKIM

Based on true events

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Over darkness, the distant sound of children playing. Beneath it, the frail murmur of an old man's prayer.

SHEIKH ISA (O.S.)
Ya Allah... guide what remains of me.

1 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / SHEIKH ISA'S PRAYER ROOM – DAY – 1932**

A Qur'an rests open on a carved wooden stand. Prayer beads hang from the wrist of aged hands cupped in prayer.

SHEIKH ISA (O.S.)
Forgive what was weak in me. Accept
what was done in Your name.

SHEIKH ISA BIN ALI AL-KHALIFA (80's) kneels on a prayer mat near the window. The sounds of children drift in from outside – laughter, the bright chaos of life continuing.

SUPER: MANAMA/BAHRAIN – 1932

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
And before I return to You... let me
know whether I honoured the trust that
was given to me.

Footsteps approach.

NOURA (10) appears in the doorway behind Sheikh Isa. Bright-eyed, caught between childhood and the first stirrings of duty. She sidles inside, trying to hide.

Sheikh Isa lifts his weathered face, his eyes still sharp.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
(teasing)
I know you are there, Noura.

Noura freezes, embarrassed.

NOURA
Sorry, Grandfather. We were playing
hide and seek.

SHEIKH ISA
Then you chose a poor hiding place. I
found you too easily.

A small smile. He gestures to her –

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
Come. Sit with me a while.

Noura enters and settles beside him. She notices the open Qur'an, the prayer beads still resting in his hand.

NOURA

Were you asking Allah for something?

SHEIKH ISA

For guidance.

NOURA

You are Hakim.

SHEIKH ISA

That is why I need it most.

NOURA

Even now, Grandfather?

SHEIKH ISA

I am not so old, Noura, that I stopped learning.

NOURA

Is that how you became so wise?

SHEIKH ISA

Wisdom comes with lessons learned.

(beat)

When I was your age, I thought a dream was only something a man saw in his sleep. I have learned the dreams that change the world are different.

Noura listens with the solemn attention of a child sensing she is being trusted with something important.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I've spent my life trying to understand my father's dream. Trying to unravel its meaning.

NOURA

Is it like a puzzle?

Sheikh Isa grips the prayer beads tightly. His eyes mist.

SHEIKH ISA

I suppose it is.

NOURA

I'm good at puzzles.

He turns to her and smiles broadly.

SHEIKH ISA

Do you have time this morning to
sit with your grandfather a while?

NOURA

Off course. I'd like that very much.

SHEIKH ISA

Then let me tell you about
blessings and burdens - and lessons
learned.

Isa turns back toward the window. His old eyes drift past the
children, past the sunlight, into memory.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Maybe together we can solve the
puzzle of my father's dream -

2 **INT. YOUNG ISA'S BEDROOM - MORNING - 1861**

2

The eyes of young ISA (13) open at the CALL OF A CRIER.

He's slept in. He throws himself from the bed, pulls on his
clothes, splashes water on his face, rushes to the door, as -

Through the window -

MANAMA sprawls below. Smoke from ovens. Masts in the harbour. A
place made of labour, trade, tide and ambition.

SUPER: MANAMA/BAHRAIN - 1861

3 **EXT. MANAMA - MORNING - CONTINUOUS**

3

MERCHANTS lifting shutters, dragging crates, counting yesterday's
fortunes and today's risks.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Before offices, before men arrived
with maps and treaties, Bahrain
listened to the sea. It fed us. It
tested us. It took from us. And
still our men returned to it.

BUILDERS chant in rhythm as they haul timber into place.

Boats rock at anchor. Nets are shaken out. Donkeys are led through
narrow lanes. Women draw water. Men work by the shore.

Bahrain feels alive - restless, practical, unsentimental.

Isa on horseback rides at breakneck speed through the waking town.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

The nakhuda knew the stars. The diver
knew the dark beneath the water. The
women knew the sound of waiting.

Isa rides past a BLACKSMITH clanging metal. Past CARPENTERS
carrying beams on their shoulders. Past MERCHANTS arguing
cheerfully. Past DATE SELLERS arranging their stock.

The town belongs to Isa, and he belongs to it.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

And I, born to the desert, believed I
knew. Land, people, blood, faith - we
are told to protect these. But no one
tells us how both burdens and
blessings can be part of the same
journey.

The twin minarets of AL-KHAMIS MOSQUE rise in the distance.

4

EXT. GATES OF PALACE - MORNING - CONTINUOUS

4

As Isa rides past the gates of the palace, HAYA (12) daughter of
the ruler, runs out from the courtyard.

HAYA

Isa! Wait!

He pulls up, smiling, as she hurries to his side.

HAYA (CONT'D)

Dates. For the breakfast you clearly
never ever eat.

She hands him a small cloth bundle. He takes it. For a moment,
they simply look at one another.

ISA

Thank you, Haya.

HAYA

Why are you always in such a rush?

Isa laughs, already turning his horse.

ISA

Because life will not slow down for me
to catch it.

He spurs forward. Haya watches him ride away, smiling – admiration, and something more.

5 **EXT. COASTAL ROAD – MORNING – MOMENTS LATER**

5

Three BAHRAINI BOYS ride toward the harbour. Isa effortlessly sweeps up beside them.

ISA
You ride like old men on turtles!

He rockets ahead, as the boys roar with laughter and give chase.

6 **EXT. PEARLING VILLAGE / DOCK – MORNING – CONTINUOUS**

6

On the outskirts of Manama, a small village by the water – modest in its dwellings, rich in pearls. Dhows ghost through the morning mist. Pearl divers haul ropes along the dock.

Isa dismounts. Runs along the dock.

HASSAN (70s) an old nakhuda – a pearling sea captain – inspects the rigging of his moored dhow, testing each knot.

ISA
Morning, Hassan. You greet the sea
before your own wife?

HASSAN
The sea complains less, Young Isa.

Isa climbs down a ladder to a humble rowboat tied below.

AHMED (15) his older brother, waits aboard. Steady where Isa is restless. Composed where Isa is all spark and motion.

AHMED
Late again, little brother.

ISA
Only when you come early, Ahmed.

AHMED
I came with the tide. You came with
excuses. Where are the others?

A shout from the dock.

BOY
Here!

Above them - the other boys arrive breathless from the ride, clutching ropes and baskets.

Isa beams.

ISA
See? Perfect timing.

7 **EXT. ROWBOAT / NEAR COAST - DAY -LATER**

7

An anchor is dropped.

The small rowboat bobs a hundred metres from shore, surrounded by working dhows. Pearl divers vanish beneath the surface one by one, ropes trailing after them into the blue.

The boys prepare to dive.

ISA
They say the pearling is good here.

AHMED
They say many things.

He dives in. A clean, fearless plunge.

BOY #1
What is he after?

AHMED
The black pearl.

BOY #2
That is only a legend.

AHMED
Tell that to Isa.

Ahmed sighs, then dives after his brother.

8 **EXT. BELOW THE SURFACE - DAY - CONTINUOUS**

8

Another world. Blue-green light. Coral. Fish scattering like thrown jewels.

Isa is at home in the sea.

Above him, Ahmed and the others follow, less certain, less graceful.

Isa goes deeper.

Sunlight spears through the water. Sound falls away. Only current. Blood. Breath held against time.

Isa cuts lower, longer, deeper than he needs to – chasing the seabed lower.

Ahmed sees this and gestures sharply: enough.

Isa ignores him.

He reaches the bottom, searching among shell and stone with fierce concentration – trying to prove something, though perhaps even he does not know what.

His hand brushes coral. Silt blooms. Then he sees it.

A shell wedged beneath rock.

Isa reaches for it. Fingers close around it. He pulls it free.

9

EXT. SEA SURFACE / ROWBOAT – DAY – MOMENTS LATER

9

Ahmed bursts up first. Then one boy. Then another. They wipe water from their faces, gasping.

No Isa. A flicker of concern. Ahmed scans the water.

Then Isa explodes through the surface, gulping air, wild with triumph. He holds up his prize. A shell.

The boys laugh with relief. They clamber back aboard their boat.

Isa works a knife into the shell, prying it open with exaggerated care. The boys crowd around.

At last, he holds up the tiniest pearl imaginable. Barely a pearl.

AHMED

You nearly drowned for that?

BOY #1

It is not even a little black.

The boys laugh.

ISA

I shall find it one day. The sea can not hide it forever.

He grins – impossible not to like.

Ahmed's eyes drift past Isa. His smile fades.

A ship at anchor by the bend. Low. Fast. Sinister.

AHMED

Pirates.

The boys turn.

9A ON THE DOCK

9A

Figures run. Screams carry faintly over the water.

SOMALI PIRATES HURL jars of naphtha – a crude local “fire oil” made from pitch/bitumen, resin, and sulphur. The jars smash. A pirate’s torch arcs through the air. Lands.

WHOOMPH. The oil erupts in flames.

Ignited oil spreads across the dock, the surface of the sea, cutting Hassan’s dhow off, trapping it inside a ring of flame.

Pirates retreat with stolen goods toward their boats.

On the trapped dhow, Hassan chokes in smoke as the flames close in.

Isa steps to the edge of the boat. Ahmed grabs him by the arm.

AHMED (CONT'D)

You cannot reach him through that.

ISA

Then I’ll go under it.

Isa tears free and dives.

AHMED

Isa!

Isa swims towards the burning dhow.

10 **EXT. DOCK – DAY- SAME**

10

BAHRAINI FIGHTERS charge into the chaos, swords drawn.

At their head is ALI BIN KHALIFA AL KHALIFA (40s) – father to Ahmed and Isa. He cuts through the pirates with controlled ferocity, then sees the nakhuda, the burning water. Sees Isa swimming towards the flames.

ALI

Isa!

10A EXT. UNDERWATER

10A

Isa drives down beneath the burning surface. Above him, the sea is on fire — a living ceiling of flame, rippling orange and black. He swims hard, eyes open against the sting, the heat pressing down through the water.

Isa reaches the dhow — rises inside the ring of flame.

IBRAHIM (20's) Ali's eldest son, leads more riders onto the flaming dock. With swift, brutal discipline, they fall upon pirates who have not escaped.

10B EXT. ON THE DOCK

10B

Hassan can barely breathe. He's terrified.

Isa scrambles aboard. Flames lick closer across the oil-slick water. The dock is fully ablaze.

Isa looks to shore. No path. Only fire.

ISA
Hold your breath.

The old man is frozen with fear. Isa grabs him.

ISA (CONT'D)
Now!

He hauls him over the side. They plunge beneath the flames.

11 EXT. UNDERWATER — DAY — CONTINUOUS

11

Isa drags Hassan beneath the burning slick.

Above them, fire rolls across the surface. No escape.

Isa kicks hard. Too hard.

The old man slips from his grasp.

Isa catches him again, but his strength is failing. His lungs burn. His limbs slow. His body begins to convulse.

A stream of air escapes him.

Then — a shape cuts through the water.

A DIVING STONE tied to a trailing rope.

12 **EXT. DOCK — DAY— CONTINUOUS** 12

13 EXT. UNDERWATER - DAY- CONTINUOUS 13

14 EXT. DOCK / SHORELINE - DAY - CONTINUOUS 14

Beyond them, men stamp at the flames still eating the dock.

ALI (CONT'D)
 Courage without thought is
 foolishness. Do you understand?

Isa lowers his eyes. He nods.

Ahmed and the other boys have landed their boat nearby. Ahmed runs forward, relieved his brother is alive.

ALI (CONT'D)
 And you, Ahmed. You didn't have the
 sense to stop your brother?

Ahmed bows his head, ashamed.

Ibrahim rides up.

IBRAHIM
 Father may not reach you next time,
 Isa.

Insult to injury.

HASSAN
 May Allah preserve the boy.

Ali glances at him, then back to Isa.

SHEIKH ALI
 And preserve him from himself.

Ali spins on his heels and heads to the dock to help with putting out the flames. Ibrahim follows. So does Ahmed.

Isa is left shaken. He knows how close he came to death.

SHIEKH ISA (V.O.)
 A man was trapped.

15 INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / SHEIKH ISA'S PRAYER ROOM - DAY - 1932

SHEIKH ISA
 I saw only his life. My father saw
 mine as well. That was the first
 valuable lesson he taught me.

Noura sits forward.

NOURA
 Was that his dream? To be rid of the
 pirates?

Isa smiles faintly.

SHEIKH ISA
Perhaps one piece of it.
(a beat)
But a good puzzle is never so generous
as to give itself away at the
beginning.

Noura smiles. She is enjoying this immensely.

NOURA
Tell me more, Grandfather.

Isa shuts his eyes - remembering again.

16 **INT. BRITISH HMS TEAZER - OFFICE - DAY - 1861**

16

A pen scratches across parchment.

SHEIKH MOHAMMED BIN KHALIFA (50s), ruler of Bahrain, Haya's father, signs the British agreement. Across the room, British officers watch in stiff silence.

Behind Mohammed stand SHEIKH ALI, young ISA, and his brothers - absorbing the moment without yet understanding its full weight.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
I was still a boy when your great
grandfather, Sheikh Mohammed, signed
the agreement with the British. They
said it would protect our ships from
pirates and keep the Gulf safe.

The British officer takes the signed document. Young Isa watches his uncle's face. There is no triumph in it.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
But sometimes, Noura, when powerful
men offer peace, they also ask you to
give something up. Your freedom. Your
ships. Your choices. I did not
understand that then.

17 **INT. BRITISH HMS TEAZER - OFFICE - DAY - 1868 - TIME CUT**

17

The same room. Different British faces.

SHEIKH ALI (50s now) sits in the same chair once occupied by his brother. He signs another declaration.

Behind him stand IBRAHIM (30s), AHMED (21), and ISA (19) - no longer boys.

SUPER: BAHRAIN - 1868

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Years passed. Relations between the British and Sheikh Mohammed soured, and he left for Zubarah. My father had to sit in that same chair.

Ali finishes signing. The British officer gathers the paper.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

They gave him a choice, but not the kind a man wants. He signed not to be made ruler, but to keep Bahrain safe from the danger it would face from every side.

Young Isa watches his father rise.

18 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE - SHEIKH ALI'S PALACE / COURTYARD - DAY - 1868**

Sheikh Ali, Ibrahim and Ahmed sit at a long table in the shaded courtyard, relaxed and content.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

When my father became ruler, the lessons did not end. They became harder.

Isa enters, dust on his clothes, energy still in him. He snatches up an apple and bites into it.

AHMED

Isa. Last to arrive, first to eat.

ISA

Or you'd leave me with crumbs, Ahmed.

The courtyard is alive with privilege and purpose.

Servants hold falcons and hawks, their wings flashing in the sun. Tribal chiefs in vivid robes confer from high-backed chairs. A SERVANT draws syrup from a madbasa date press.

Beside Ali sit his WIFE and adviser, SALEH, 30s. Nearby stands MAJEED, 21, Ali's assistant - almost invisible.

SALEH

The first harvest reports are strong, Your Honour. The best in years.

Sheikh Ali nods, troubled.

Across the courtyard, Isa and Ahmed have already drawn practice swords, circling one another. Isa moves with flourish. Ahmed with easy amusement.

Isa knocks a serving dish from a passing servant's tray. Majeed catches it before it hits the ground. No one notices.

The boys beckon Ibrahim to join. Ibrahim looks to Sheikh Ali.

Ali smiles, giving permission.

Ibrahim rises and draws his sword.

A SALUKI noses after scraps beneath the table as the brothers move into the open space.

Steel whispers, then rings.

Ahmed grins through the play. Ibrahim is composed and economical. Isa attacks with flair – but too much force.

AHMED

There he is. Fighting the air harder
than the man.

Isa presses harder. Ibrahim turns aside each strike with irritating ease.

IBRAHIM

Careful, Isa. Haste is not victory.

Ahmed sees the change first.

AHMED

Isa –

Isa lunges. The play gone. Steel cracks. Ibrahim gives ground now, forced to work as Isa drives at him with real anger.

Isa strikes HARDER. The tip of his blade flashes past Ibrahim's face – close enough to draw a breath from everyone watching.

Suddenly, Sheikh Ali is between them, gripping Isa's sword arm.

SHEIKH ALI

Enough.

Isa stands breathing hard. Ibrahim steps back, no longer smiling. Ali takes the sword from Isa's hand.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

The Prophet said the strong man is not the one who overcomes others by force, but the one who controls himself in anger.

ISA

He provoked me.

SHEIKH ALI

If mockery can govern you, you are already in another man's hands.

That stings.

Ali offers the sword back, hilt first.

Isa takes the sword, chastened but listening, the lesson burning deeper than the reprimand.

19 **EXT. TREE OF LIFE - DUSK**

19

A majestic FALCON glides across the darkening sky, riding the last warm currents of the day.

Beneath the vast canopy of the TREE OF LIFE, SHEIKH ALI stands with his three sons: IBRAHIM, AHMED, and ISA. The desert stretches endlessly around them. Nothing should grow here, but this one tree stands defiantly.

Ali places a hand against the tree's ancient bark.

SHEIKH ALI

Look at this tree, my sons. It lives.
While nothing around it does. Its
roots reach where the eye cannot.

The boys listen. Ibrahim calm authority. Ahmed quiet attention. Isa restless, eager to understand, but even more to be noticed.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Bahrain is not only what we see.

He offers a water bladder to Ibrahim first. Ibrahim drinks, then passes it to Ahmed. Ahmed drinks and passes it to Isa.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

The country provides. Even where the
eye sees only sand.

Isa drinks, watching his father.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Fresh water springs beneath the waves.
Allah's miracle. Two seas. One salt,
one fresh.

Isa passes the bladder back to his father.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Since our ancestors founded Al-
Zubarah, we have known peace and
challenge. Wisdom secures allies.
Wealth invites rivals.

He pours a thin stream of water onto the soil beneath the Tree.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

This is why we build bridges, not
walls. Why we keep our alliances
strong.

Isa watches the water vanish instantly into the thirsty ground.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Even when the British speak of peace
as though it were theirs to give.
Their treaties are written on shifting
sands.

The falcon descends and lands on Ibrahim's arm. Natural. Almost
accidental. But Isa notices.

IBRAHIM

They say they restrain piracy. Yet
little by little, every fleet on this
coast grows smaller but their own.

AHMED

What is the answer, Father?

SHEIKH ALI

We strengthen our alliances.

Isa cannot hold back.

ISA

Why call them allies?

IBRAHIM

(cautioning)

Isa.

SHEIKH ALI

You speak as though courage and
patience are enemies.

(MORE)

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

(a beat)

You must also learn to listen. That is where wisdom begins.

The rebuke lands hard.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

There is more to our land than pearls,
or how the British measure us. More
than fresh water beneath the sea.

Isa listens, not fully understanding, but feeling the weight in his father's voice.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

I believe it. I dream of it.

Ibrahim raises his arm. The falcon launches into the dusk.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

One day, Ibrahim, you will carry forth
that dream.

The words strike Isa harder than any reprimand.

Ibrahim bows his head.

IBRAHIM

It will be my duty and my honour,
Father.

Isa hides the hurt, watching the falcon fly into the distance.

20 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE - SHEIKH ALI'S PALACE / RAMPARTS - NIGHT**

ISA stands alone. Restless. Troubled. The argument at the Tree still burns in him.

The sky is a canopy of stars. In the distant harbour, a ship's lantern sways in the dark.

SHEIKH ALI (O.S.)

Bahrain is a ship, Isa.

Isa turns as his father approaches.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Some men pull the ropes. Some dive
beneath the water. Some watch the
stars. Some pray on the shore.

He places a hand on Isa's shoulder.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

But if any one loses his nerve, all
of them drown.

ISA

You ask Ibrahim what he thinks. You
never ask me.

SHEIKH ALI

Ibrahim has his path. Ahmed has
his. And you - you shall play your
part in time.

The weight of what his father is to say sits heavily between them.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

You must study. Beyond our shores.
In England.

The words hit Isa like exile.

ISA

You are sending me away?

SHEIKH ALI

I am preparing you.

ISA

For what? To be useful somewhere
else?

For a moment, father and son face one another in the starlight.

SHEIKH ALI

The world is moving faster. The
British understand this. If we
remain only what we have been,
Bahrain will be swept aside.

ISA

I want to be here. I want to stand
beside you. If there is a fight,
then let me fight it with you.

SHEIKH ALI

Anger is a poor navigator, Isa.

Isa has no answer. Only hurt.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

The sea has fed us. Pearls are the
blessing we know. There are other
blessings to be found.

(MORE)

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

The land has not yet spoken. When
it does, someone must know how to
listen.

He studies Isa's face - his youth, his fire, his impatience.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Isa, you must learn what cannot yet
be taught here. I may one day need
from you what no one else can give.

At last, Isa nods. Not gladly. But he nods.

Ali places hands on his shoulders, gently kisses his forehead.

21 **EXT. DESERT - DAWN**

21

ISA drives his horse across the sand, trying to outrun his
father's words. He pulls up on a rise, breathing hard. He turns.

Behind him, another horse and rider approach from the distance.

HAYA (now 18) rides toward him. Her scarf streams on the wind. She
reins in hard beside him. Sharp-eyed, proud, no longer the girl he
remembers - and yet entirely the same.

HAYA

Isa. I missed you at the palace.

Their eyes hold. She senses something is wrong.

ISA

My father wants to send me away, Haya.
To study.

Anger breaks through.

ISA (CONT'D)

As if there is no use for me here.

HAYA

Is that what he said? Or are those
your words?

It stings because it is true.

ISA

(bitter)

My future no longer belongs to me.

HAYA

Your father is not punishing you, Isa.
He sees promise in you. He hopes you
return with purpose.

The sun edges higher. Gold touches their faces. Neither can say more, though both want to.

ISA

And what do you hope?

Haya lowers her eyes. Too cautious to speak.

A gust lifts Haya's scarf. Isa catches it instinctively before it slips away. For a moment, he holds the fabric. As he offers it back, their fingers brush. A brief accidental touch – gone almost before it can be acknowledged.

HAYA

Poor Isa. Always rushing to catch life
before it escapes you.

The old phrase sparks between them.

HAYA (CONT'D)

Life is a long road ahead of you. You
must learn to ride more slowly.

ISA

I have never been good at that.

Isa gathers his reins, then hesitates.

ISA (CONT'D)

Haya. If I was away a long time...
would you remember me kindly?

Haya's composure falters only slightly.

HAYA

Do not ask me such things from a
horse's back, Isa.

He understands. A sad, private smile passes between them.

ISA

Then someday I will ask better, when I
am standing on the ground.

The tenderness of it unsettles him. He nods. For a moment, neither moves. Then Isa turns his horse toward the horizon. He rides off toward the rising sun.

Haya watches him go, tears held back with difficulty.

22 **EXT. DESERT - FIRST LIGHT** 22

Majeed ON HORSEBACK streaks across the wondrous landscape.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
These were difficult lessons for a
young man. It seemed life could not
present any greater burden.

23 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE - SHEIKH ALI'S PALACE / COURTYARD -** 23
 CONTINUOUS - FIRST LIGHT

Majeed dismounts with urgency and enters the palace.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
But young men can hold foolish
thoughts. Soon I would learn the
hardest lesson of all.

24 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE - SHEIKH ALI'S PALACE / BED CHAMBER -**
 CONTINUOUS - FIRST LIGHT

Majeed rushes in to wake Ali.

MAJEED
Your Honour, Your Honour.

But Ali is already stirring. Staff accumulate in the hallway.

MAJEED (CONT'D)
Scouts report emissaries from
Zallaq approaching.

SHEIKH ALI
Zallaq? At this hour?

25 **EXT. EAST RIFFA - DAWN** 25

A cold dawn over the dunes.

SHEIKH ALI & IBRAHIM lead a large force of fifty fighters. Swords.
Rifles.

SALEH, Ali's advisor, rides at his side.

Across the field waits another force. Fifty strong as well, with
hard-faced MERCENARIES among them. Two FIELD CANNONS.

At their centre: SHEIKH MOHAMMED (60's).

Beside him: SHEIKH ABDULLAH BIN AHMED AL-KHALIFA (50s).

Ali sees his brother. Then Abdullah. Concern passes across his face, quickly buried.

SHEIKH ALI

Saleh.

Saleh rides out beneath a white cloth.

IBRAHIM

Uncle Mohammed?

SHEIKH ALI

And he brought Abdullah.

Saleh confers with Mohammed and Abdullah. Too far to hear.

IBRAHIM

What do they want?

SHEIKH ALI

Today we find out.

Saleh rides back.

SALEH

Mohammed says the British robbed him
of rule. He wants redress.

A murmur among Ali's men.

Sheikh Ali looks past him toward his brother.

SHEIKH ALI

I will hear it from his lips.

A thunder of hooves and Isa is there, ready to fight.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

This is not your place, Son.

ISA

But, Father -

SHEIKH ALI

Go back, Isa.

Isa bows his head but does not yet retreat.

Ali has no time. He turns to Ibrahim.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Ibrahim.

Ali and Ibrahim ride forward. Saleh and two FIGHTERS follow.

Across the field, Mohammed and Abdullah ride out to meet them. Several of Abdullah's mercenaries drift close behind. The two parties halt within speaking distance.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

Brother.

MOHAMMED

Ali.

SHEIKH ALI

You return to Bahrain, Brother?

MOHAMMED

I return because the British put their hands upon our house. What was mine was taken.

Abdullah looks at him, coldly amused.

ABDULLAH

Your brother deserves his share, does he not?

SHEIKH ALI

Mohammed, look carefully at the man beside you. He does not wish you well.

Ibrahim studies Mohammed - not an enemy - the uncle he knew.

IBRAHIM

There is still a path between us, Uncle.

MOHAMMED

This does not concern you, Ibrahim.

ABDULLAH

Enough.

All eyes shift to Abdullah.

ABDULLAH (CONT'D)

We did not cross the sand to discuss family disputes.

Abdullah gives the slightest signal. Saleh crosses over and joins Mohammed's line.

IBRAHIM

Traitor.

SHEIKH ALI

Ibrahim.

Then, from both flanks, more fighters crest the dunes. Fifty on one side. Fifty on the other. Isa sees the trap closing.

ISA

No.

Mohammed is terrified - it's out of control. He turns on Abdullah.

MOHAMMED

We agreed! No blood between brothers.

Abdullah smiles.

ALL AT ONCE - Abdullah draws his sword - a split second before Ibrahim draws his own.

SHEIKH ALI

Ibrahim, no!

A SHOT cracks. Ibrahim is hit. He falls from his horse.

Saleh holds the smoking pistol.

ISA

Ibrahim!

Ali draws his sword. Abdullah lunges first, driving Ali back.

The battlefield erupts. Ali's men charge. Abdullah's mercenaries open fire. Horses scream. Rifles crack. Steel flashes.

Isa kicks his horse forward, sword drawn, charging into the open. Toward Ibrahim and his father, blind to everything else.

Isa reaches Ibrahim's fallen body and swings wildly at Saleh, driving him back.

A raider comes from behind. Isa is knocked from his horse. A spear flies.

SHEIKH ALI

Isa! Save yourself!

Sheikh Ali rides into the spear's path. It strikes him in the side. Time slows.

ISA

Father!

Sheikh Ali tears the spear free with a cry, staying upright by force of will.

Gunfire rips across the dunes. Around them: riders circling, swords slashing, men falling beneath hooves.

Ali fights his way towards his son, forces his horse between Isa and the attackers.

Through the chaos, Mohammed – horrified at what he's unleashed.

MOHAMMED
Abdullah! Stop this!

Saleh moves toward the wounded Ibrahim.

MOHAMMED (CONT'D)
Saleh! No!

Saleh fires his pistol. Ibrahim's body jerks, then lies still.

Sheikh Ali's grief becomes fury. He cuts down Abdullah's men around him.

Isa screams and charges Saleh, dragging him from his horse. Saleh hits the ground hard.

Isa raises his sword to run him through – A FIELD CANNON erupts nearby. The blast kills Saleh and hurls Isa into the sand.

Isa is deafened. Only RINGING amidst dust and blood.

Through the haze, Mohammed shouts to men who no longer obey him.

MOHAMMED (CONT'D)
Stop this!

Abdullah points toward Sheikh Ali.

ABDULLAH
End it.

Two RAIDERS advance on Ali. Sheikh Ali, wounded, uses his horse for cover, still firing. Isa sees the raiders raise spears.

SHEIKH ALI
There's too many!

Isa pushes himself up, dazed and bleeding.

The spears fly. Isa stumbles toward his father. One spear tears into his leg. Another cuts across his side. He keeps moving.

Ali is shot in the chest. He falls heavily into the sand.

Isa collapses beside Ali. The battle rages around them.

SHEIKH ALI (CONT'D)

No more blood.

Ali struggles to breathe, blood on his lips. He looks beyond Isa. Ibrahim dead. His fighters decimated. His house broken.

ISA

Father, what should I do?

Isa fumbles for the leather pouch at his belt, spills water into his palm, and wipes blood from his father's face.

SHEIKH ALI

La ilaha illa Allah. Wa Muhammad rasul Allah.

Sheikh Ali's eyes glaze. He's is fading.

ISA

Stay. Please stay. I'll do anything you ask. Whatever you want. I promise, Father. I promise.

Ali stares deep into Isa's eyes. A brief smile on his lips -

SHEIKH ALI

All is not lost, my Son...

His breath leaves him. Sheikh Ali dies. Isa places a trembling hand over his father's face and gently closes his eyes.

Isa rises in a blind rage. He takes up his sword, mounts his horse, and charges Abdullah. They clash.

Isa fights through tears and fury, reckless, wounded, barely seeing. Abdullah gains the upper hand. He drives his blade into Isa, just missing the heart.

Isa drops his sword. Slumps forward, one hand tangled in the reins. His horse bolts, carrying him away from the battlefield.

Mohammed weeps as Abdullah's men drag him away.

Abdullah watches Ali's body for one cold moment. Then he turns his horse and retreats.

26 **EXT. DESERT - DAY**

26

Isa's horse - mouth foaming - walks alone through the desert. Exhaustion in every step. Isa is slumped in the saddle, barely conscious, blood dried across his robes.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
My horse carried me for miles. As far
from death as she could.

The horse reaches a low sand mound. Slows. Kneels carefully. Isa rolls from the saddle and lands in the sand.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
She gave the last of herself.

The horse circles him once, unsteady. Then collapses beside him.

Isa's eyes open. Alive. Barely. His POV: against the glare of the sun - THREE SHADOWY RIDERS.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
I would have died there if Jabir had
not found me.
(a beat)
He knew my father. He took me in.
Helped me heal.

NASSIR BIN JABIR (30s) kneels beside him.

JABIR
Pain is proof you are still alive,
son of Ali.

Jabir's men climb from their horses - lift Isa from the ground.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
My body slowly healed. But something
in me would not.

27 **EXT. EAST RIFFA - DESERT BATTLEFIELD - NIGHT - DREAM**

27

Sheikh Ali surrounded.

A WARRIOR IN BLACK moves through smoke and dust - his face hidden behind an ornate, terrifying MASK.

Isa tries to reach his father. Cannot. The Masked Man strikes. Sheikh Ali falls. Isa screams. But no sound comes.

28 **INT. JABIR'S RESIDENCE - NIGHT**

28

Isa startles awake. A dim room. A flickering lantern. Jabir stands in the doorway with water.

JABIR
You cried out again.

Isa breathes hard, disoriented.

ISA
The same dream. A masked man hunts me.
It means something, Jabir.

JABIR
Rest.

Jabir sets the water beside him.

JABIR (CONT'D)
Meaning can wait.

29 **EXT. JABIR'S RESIDENCE - STABLES - DAY**

29

Months later. A quiet courtyard beside the stables.

ISA, thinner, not fully recovered, helps a young STABLE BOY sit properly in the saddle. He moves carefully, hiding pain.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
So I rested. For many months. Until I
could stand again. Though meaning
would not come for a long time yet.

The boy pulls too tightly on the reins.

ISA
Not so tight. A horse is not a
prisoner.

He adjusts the boy's hands.

ISA (CONT'D)
Guide him. Let him feel your trust.

The boy tries again. Better. Isa gives the smallest nod.

Jabir watches from a distance with several men. He sees what Isa refuses to see: men already looking to him.

A RIDER approaches fast. The courtyard turns.

AHMED. Changed by months in hiding. Leaner. Worn down. Travel-stained. Eyes alert from too long expecting betrayal.

Ahmed dismounts. Isa crosses to him. They embrace fiercely.

ISA (CONT'D)
Ahmed.

AHMED
Alhamdulillah.

Ahmed grips his brother's shoulders, looking at him as though confirming he is real. Alive.

AHMED (CONT'D)
I prayed it was true.

ISA
I was told nothing of you.

AHMED
That was the only way to remain alive.

Jabir quietly withdraws with the others, leaving the brothers alone. Isa studies Ahmed's exhausted face.

ISA
You have been hiding all this time?

AHMED
Moving from house to house. From loyal hands to braver ones.

Isa looks to the open desert beyond the walls.

ISA
I should not have lived.

AHMED
Never say such a thing.

ISA
Father rode between me and the spear.

AHMED
Because you were his son.

ISA
Because I disobeyed him.

AHMED
That is what grief tells you. Do you believe Abdullah would have spared him? Spared Ibrahim? Spared any of us?

Isa looks away, raw.

AHMED (CONT'D)
Manama is in fear. Abdullah takes what he wants. His mercenaries bleed the merchants, threaten the divers, insult the chiefs.
(MORE)

AHMED (CONT'D)

Men who served Father now bow because
they fear the sword at their throat.

Isa says nothing.

AHMED (CONT'D)

Mohammed was cast aside and resides in
Bu Maher Fort. He opened a door and
found a fire behind it. And the
British, they wait and do nothing. As
always.

ISA

Shifting sands.

AHMED

And while they shift, Bahrain sinks.

ISA

And Haya? Does she know I lived?

AHMED

I am not certain.

Ahmed steps closer.

AHMED (CONT'D)

They speak your name, Isa. In Manama.
In Muharraq. Among the divers. Among
the merchants. They thought you dead
and mourned you as a martyr. Now they
know you live.

(beat)

You must lead.

ISA

He died in my arms, Ahmed. He said,
'All is not lost'.

Ahmed is deeply moved.

AHMED

Isa, he meant you. He looked to you as
that hope.

ISA

Do not give me this burden, Ahmed. I
am not strong enough.

AHMED

You are our hope. Father knew it.

Isa walks away a few steps, needing distance.

ISA

I cannot be what he wanted.

AHMED

Then be what Bahrain needs.

Isa looks toward the horizon beyond the stables. The country waits out there. Wounded. Calling to him.

30 **INT. BU MAHER FORT / CELL - NIGHT**

30

MOHAMMED sleeps on a hard bunk. Moonlight spills through the barred window.

Keys rattle in the door-lock and the door swings open.

In the open doorway the prison guard, a knife at his throat, is held captive by Jabir. Isa stands beside him.

MOHAMMED

Isa!

He slips from the bed and falls to the floor, terrified.

MOHAMMED (CONT'D)

It was not my doing. I swear before
Allah. I never wanted your father
dead. I never wanted Ibrahim dead.

Isa's silence is worse than rage.

31 **EXT. OPEN DESERT - PRE-DAWN**

31

Two large tents. Horses tethered. A dying fire. TWO GUARDS slump asleep outside.

From behind a low ridge, ISA, AHMED, JABIR, and JABIR'S MEN watch the hunting camp below. Mohammed sits bound and gagged on a horse, held in place by one of Jabir's men. Ahmed watches Isa, uncertain whether this is justice or vengeance.

AHMED

Isa.

Isa does not look at him.

ISA

No blood. Unless there is no choice.

Isa nods to Jabir. Jabir's men move. Silent. Low. Fast.

32 **EXT. ABDULLAH'S CAMP - CONTINUOUS**

32

One guard wakes too late. A hand over his mouth. A blade to his throat. The second guard reaches for his weapon and is struck down before he can cry out.

Jabir's men quickly surround the main tent.

33 **INT. ABDULLAH'S TENT - CONTINUOUS**

33

ABDULLAH sleeps fully dressed, a sword within reach.

Jabir's men enter like shadows.

Abdullah's eyes snap open. He grabs his sword and lunges. For a moment, he is all fury – dangerous, fast, animal. But there are too many of them.

34 **EXT. ABDULLAH'S CAMP - CONTINUOUS**

34

Abdullah is dragged from the tent. Fear cuts through his arrogance.

ABDULLAH
I do not fear death, son of Ali.

Isa steps closer trembling with rage. He glares at the man who destroyed his family.

35 **EXT.HMS DAPHNE -BRIDGE / OFF THE COAST OF MANAMA - DAY**

35

A young soldier looks through a spyglass.

SOLDIER
Vessels approaching, Sir.

British Political Resident PELLY and a fire hydrant of a man, COLONEL ROSS look towards the sea with their own telescopes.

SPYGLASS POV – Isa stands at the prow of a dhow. Ahmed beside him. Many dhows follow – an escort worthy of a new ruler.

PELLY
It's the young Al-Khalifa.

ROSS
By God. They're rallying to him.

36 **EXT. HMS DAPHNE / DECK - MOMENTS LATER**

36

ISA, still carrying the stiffness of his wounds, climbs aboard with AHMED. Behind them: ABDULLAH and MOHAMMED, bound and shackled, escorted by JABIR and two of his men. Beyond, the sea is crowded with Bahraini sails.

COLONEL ROSS and PELLY wait on deck.

ROSS

Sheikh Isa. We had word you restored your family's rule. Congratulations.

PELLY

You have brought quite a fleet of supporters.

ISA

They brought me.

ROSS

Your people will rejoice. These last months have not served Bahrain well.

ISA

Yet you did nothing to change that.

Pelly clears his throat.

ROSS

May your reign be long, Sheikh Isa.

ISA

May it be my own.

(beat)

With my brother by my side.

PELLY

Britain offers Bahrain its continued protection.

ISA

I will honour the agreement you held with my father. No more. No less.

Ross glances toward Abdullah and Mohammed.

PELLY

What would you like done with them?

ROSS

Swift punishment would make an example.

ISA
If I begin with blood, I will spend my
reign feeding it.
(a beat)
Exile them.

Mohammed lowers his head. Abdullah's eyes burn with hatred.

ROSS
As you wish.

37 **EXT. STREETS OF MANAMA - DAY**

37

DRUMS. SONG. JUBILATION. A nation rejoices. Streets overflow.
Sheikh Isa's symbol on countless flags. Palm fronds wave.

CROWD
Sheikh Isa! Sheikh Isa! Sheikh Isa!

ISA rides through the crowd, accompanied by FIGHTERS and his
SALUKIS. The people surge around him, ecstatic.

An elderly woman and her husband sprinkle rose water before him.
Women cast petals at his horse's feet. A boy pulls off his gutra
and waves it like a flag. Isa receives it all with humility.

As the crowd parts -

HAYA stands ahead of him.

Isa dismounts. They face one another in the street.

The crowd fall into a respectful silence.

HAYA
I thought I had lost you.

ISA
No, Haya. I'm here.

Her composure trembles, but does not break.

HAYA
Whatever my father's intentions,
whatever his regrets, he stood with
Abdullah. They brought ruin upon your
house.

She glances away, ashamed despite herself.

ISA
Our marriage will heal what others
tried to break.

The word touches her before she can prepare for it. Her eyes fill.

HAYA
Perhaps I had hoped for mercy.
Forgiveness. Not this.

ISA
Your father's mistakes are not yours.

HAYA
Others will not see it that way.

ISA
Then let them learn.

She studies him, startled by the certainty.

HAYA
And if I say yes - is it for me? Or
for Bahrain?

He could lie. He does not.

ISA
For you. For what I feel. For what
Bahrain will need. I no longer know
how to divide these things.

The honesty moves her more than comfort would have.

HAYA
I have carried my father's name like a
stone in my chest.

ISA
Then put it down.

Isa steps closer, as the crowd hold their collective breath.

HAYA
May love grow between us.

ISA
Ameen.

Isa takes her hand. The crowd erupts in joy.

38 INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE/ MAJLIS - DAY

38

TRIBAL LEADERS, ruling family members, merchants, elders, and men from across Bahrain sit shoulder to shoulder. Coffee passes hand to hand. Respectful. Uneasy.

At the centre sits SHEIKH ISA. Beside him, SHEIKH AHMED.

MAJEED sits near Isa & Ahmed. JABIR is present with several men of the AL-NAIEM TRIBE – who sheltered Isa.

All eyes are on the young man now expected to rule.

YUSUF FAKHRO

(rising)

Sheikh Ali, may Allah rest his soul,
gave Bahrain strength when strength
was needed. We honour his house. We
honour the blood that was shed.

Murmurs of agreement.

SALEM BIN HAMAD, head of the Al-Bin Ali Tribe, rises.

SALEM BIN HAMAD

Honour is not in question. You are
your father's son. What we ask is
how you will repair a Bahrain that
has been broken.

The room murmurs.

SHEIKH ISA

By beginning with the truth.

(beat)

Speak plainly. I am listening.

Voices rise. Grievances overlap.

MERCHANT ELDER

Our boats need safe routes.

YUSUF FAKHRO

Abdullah's mercenaries left many
with nothing.

MERCHANT ELDER

Merchants have suffered. Families
suffer still.

ANOTHER ELDER

We need medicine. Fever kills as
surely as a blade.

BEDOUIN ELDER

Men walk from East Riffa for water.
Children thirst while men argue.

YUSUF FAKHRO

We need more than words. We need actions.

Ahmed rises, hands out to calm them. Loudly, to be heard -

SHEIKH AHMED

Sheikh Isa did not call you here only for words.

They calm.

SHEIKH ISA

Water. Medicine. Safer routes. Protection for the divers, the merchants, and the families left exposed by this blood. These will be our first duties.

(turns to Majeed)

To the widows of those who stood with us, I say, no child is to go hungry because his father answered our call.

Majeed takes notes as a ripple moves through the room.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

The poor will be provided for. Houses broken by Abdullah's violence will be restored.

Ahmed watches him, impressed but wary.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

And the Al-Naiem, who sheltered me, will not be forgotten.

Jabir lowers his eyes, moved.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Forty-one purebred horses. Weapons. Garments. Coin.

The room reacts. Generous. Perhaps too generous.

SHEIKH AHMED

(low, to Isa)

Careful, brother. Promise what can be kept.

SALEM BIN HAMAD

Generosity honours loyalty. But generosity does not build wells.

SHEIKH ISA

No. Men do.

The room quiets.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

So each tribe will give what it can:
men, routes, protection. The merchants
will help fund what serves all trade.
My house will carry the burden first.
For wells. For medicine. For guards on
the roads and along the shore. For a
Bahrain that does not wait for
permission to survive.

SALEM BIN HAMAD

And what do you ask in return?

SHEIKH ISA

Unity.

Isa looks from face to face.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

If one tribe thirsts, Bahrain is
weaker. If one fleet is preyed upon,
every merchant pays. If loyalty is
forgotten, no man will risk loyalty
again.

Ahmed watches his brother now with quiet pride.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Stand with me, and I will stand with
you. Question me in this room, not
behind my back. Bring me your troubles
before they become grievances.

Silence. Then Salem Bin Hamad rises.

SALEM BIN HAMAD

The Al-Bin Ali will stand with you.

A murmur of approval. Yusuf Fakhro rises.

YUSUF FAKHRO

As will my house.

JABIR

(rises)

And the Al-Naiem.

One by one, other elders rise.

SHEIKH AHMED

Then let it be known. We stand as one
house, one people, one Bahrain.

The room answers.

VOICES

One Bahrain.

More join.

VOICES (CONT'D)

One Bahrain.

The call grows until the whole majlis speaks as one.

ALL

One Bahrain.

Isa stands at the centre of it, sobered by what he has accepted.
Ahmed & Isa exchange looks.

The tribes have come together.

39 **EXT. WEDDING VENUE - EVENING**

39

A field of Bedouin tents glows beneath the falling light. Rugs
cover the desert floor. Lanterns sway. Incense smoke curls from a
MUGBASS as a man wafts it through the air. Drums rise.

SHEIKH ISA and SHEIKHA HAYA ride in a decorated carriage, MEN ON
HORSEBACK circle behind them. The crowd cheers, claps in rhythm.

The carriage circles the wedding ground. Then halts as Isa steps
down and offers his hand to Haya. Amid all the ceremony, they are
simply bride and groom.

LATER - BY AN OPEN FIRE

IMAM SAUD BIN FAISAL (30s) stands before Sheikh Isa, holding an
ornate sword wrapped in silk.

The surrounding guests fall quiet.

IMAM SAUD

This sword, Al-Ajrab, belonged to my
grandfather, Imam Turki bin Abdullah
Al Saud.

He unwraps the silk, revealing the legendary blade.

IMAM SAUD (CONT'D)

Now it is passed to you.

(a beat)

Your father, Sheikh Ali, was a true friend to me. He gave shelter and support when it was needed.

SHEIKH ISA

I shall honour him. And the friendship he shared will continue between us.

Imam Saud extends the sword.

IMAM SAUD

May it remind future generations how Al Khalifa and Al Saud stood together.

Isa accepts the sword. Firelight runs along the blade.

Sword dancers move in widening circles, rifles and blades catching firelight as the rhythm builds.

40 **INT. WEDDING TENT - NIGHT**

40

The celebration continues. Incense drifts. Music rises. The tent is divided with elegance and custom.

On one side, MEN gather in greetings and formal congratulations.

ISA stands with AHMED, receiving guests. Nearby: PELLY and COLONEL ROSS. Isa warmly accepts a wedding gift from a RABBI.

Beyond a screen of embroidered fabric, the WOMEN'S GATHERING glows with colour, perfume, and conversation.

SHEIKHA HAYA sits with the senior women. Haya notices ZALAIKHA standing apart with her INFANT SON.

Haya crosses to her.

SHEIKHA HAYA

Zalaikha?

Zalaikha bows her head.

ZALAIKHA

Mabrook my Sheikha, may your lives be long and blessed.

SHEIKHA HAYA

A woman who marries a ruler does not marry only a man.

(MORE)

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

She marries his people, his burdens,
and the weight they place upon his
shoulders.

ZALAIKHA

Yes, my Sheikha.

SHEIKHA HAYA

Your husband served Sheikh Ali until
the end. I would be grateful if you
would come and assist me.

Zalaikha is startled by the honour.

ZALAIKHA

I would be honoured, my Sheikha.

Haya looks at the child and gently places a hand on his head.

SHEIKHA HAYA

The child has a fever.

ZALAIKHA

My Sheikha, the medicine promised
has still not come.

MEN'S GATHERING

A wealthy merchant MUGBIL BIN ABDUL RAHMAN AL-THUKAIR (50s)
speaks to Isa with mischief in his eyes. Others listen intently.

THUKAIR

Tell me, Your Honour. When I reach the
afterlife, I will be older than my
father by at least ten years. He
passed in his fortieth year, and here
I sit past my fiftieth, still
breathing.

The men listen with interest.

THUKAIR (CONT'D)

So when I see him, do I kiss his head,
or does he kiss mine?

The men roar with laughter. Isa laughs too.

Haya waits until Isa glances her way.

She touches two fingers lightly to her wrist - a private reminder.
Then places that hand over her heart.

Isa understands. He turns back to the men.

SHEIKH ISA
Mr. Pelly.

PELLY
Your Honour.

SHEIKH ISA
On such a happy evening, I hesitate to
speak of sickness. However -

Pelly offers a courteous smile, sensing the trap.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
The medicines promised by your
government have not arrived.

PELLY
Arrangements are underway. These
matters require transport, approval,
suitable personnel. There are delays.

SHEIKH ISA
Hmm. I think we should have a
hospital.

PELLY
(he blinks)
A hospital?

SHEIKH ISA
A modest one, of course. Properly
stocked with medicines. So we don't
have delays. A doctor. Perhaps two. Do
you think the British Empire can
supply this humble request?

A few nearby men chuckle. Ross's mouth tightens.

PELLY
Your Honour, a hospital is not a small
undertaking.

Isa lowers his voice, still charming but precise.

SHEIKH ISA
You have agreed to medicine. I merely
suggest we give your promise a roof.

Pelly can't retreat, so forces a smile.

PELLY
I will raise the matter.

SHEIKH ISA
Excellent.

Across the screen, Haya watches, proud but composed.

41 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / STUDY - NIGHT**

41

By candlelight, ISA writes at his desk. Outside, the stars shimmer across a glassy sea.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
A man thinks he understands his father
when he buries him. He does not. He
understands him when he holds his own
child and realizes he too will one day
leave something unfinished.

MAJEED enters, breathless with joy.

MAJEED
Your Honour! Your son is born!

42 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / BED CHAMBER - LATER**

42

SHEIKHA HAYA lies exhausted but radiant. She places their newborn son into Isa's arms.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
When Salman was born, I began to
understand the shape of a father's
dreams.

Isa holds the child carefully. He crosses to the window and lifts the baby toward the distant lights of Manama.

SHEIKH ISA
Look, little Salman. One day you will
play your part.

The city glimmers beside the dark water. Then, far beyond the harbour – a flicker of orange. Flames.

Isa's smile fades.

Across the sea, a ship burns against the horizon.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
And the shape of his fears.

43 **EXT. VILLAGE HARBOUR / TRADING POST - NIGHT - 1878**

43

SUPER: BAHRAIN - 1878

Dark figures in multiple landing boats emerge from the black sea. They climb onto the dock silently, with practiced purpose. One slips beneath a dhow and drives a blade into its hull.

Across the harbour, more pirates climb aboard anchored boats – cutting rigging, smashing rudders, ruining a season's labour before a cry is raised.

The harbour erupts. Traders spill out half-dressed.

The pirates surge toward the TRADING POST. Doors are kicked in. Chests broken open. A torch flies through a warehouse window. Glass shatters. Fire takes hold.

A burning pearling boat breaks loose and drifts into two others. Flames leap from sail to sail.

A weathered nakhuda is dragged from his vessel, bloodied but defiant. Pirates sort stolen cargo by torchlight: pearls, provisions, rifles, powder.

At the centre of it all stands KHALIL (30s) broad-shouldered, watchful. Commanding. A brutal scar runs across his face. Not enough merely to steal. He wants Bahrain afraid.

Beside him, a CHINESE FEMALE PIRATE – BAMEI (20s) fierce and exhilarated – joins the plunder.

Khalil gives a signal. The pirates retreat to their waiting boats, leaving fire, panic, and sabotaged boats sinking into the sea –

HORSES THUNDER in from the darkness.

SHEIKH ISA (now 30) rides hard with SHEIKH AHMED (32) and a dozen FIGHTERS. Isa & Ahmed draw swords.

SHEIKH ISA
Cut them off from the water!

Ahmed and the fighters split wide, driving toward the dock and the trading post.

The pirates scatter. A few turn to fight.

Isa crashes into them, fast and merciless, knocking one man from his feet and driving another back into the burning light.

Ahmed reaches the edge of the dock and cuts down a pirate about to strike the nakhuda.

Isa reaches the edge too late. His horse rears at the flames.

Khalil retreats on a boat, with the Female Pirate. He sees Isa through the chaos. Their eyes meet across flame and water.

For a moment, Khalil smiles. Then vanishes behind a wall of smoke.

44 **INT. BRITISH HMS TEAZER / MEETING ROOM - DAY**

44

ISA and AHMED stand before COLONEL ROSS, CAPTAIN STEWART, and CLIVE KIRKPATRICK DALY (25) sharp-eyed and insolent.

SHEIKH ISA
His name is Khalil.

SHEIKH AHMED
They call him the Butcher.

SHEIKH ISA
Four crewmen dead. Weeks of trade
stolen. Families ruined. How can a
country live if every season the sea
is handed back to thieves?

ROSS
We will investigate. Britain has
Bahrain's best interests at heart.

SHEIKH AHMED
His name is spoken in every harbour.
His men sell stolen goods where your
officers pass. His fires blight our
shores. Bahrain knows Khalil. Why does
Britain not?

Isa steadies Ahmed with the lightest touch at the elbow.

CAPTAIN STEWART
We do not take these losses lightly.
One of our own ships was damaged.

SHEIKH ISA
Khalil's method is always the same.
Raid, burn, then flee by fast craft to
his waiting ship.

DALY
We cannot police the entire sea.

ROSS
Everyone here is doing what can be
done.

CAPTAIN STEWART
Bring me routes. Suppliers. Something
firmer, and I will pursue him.

Daly stares down Stewart, who is clearly speaking out of turn.

DALY
Captain, perhaps we might first
consider if the intelligence is
reliable. Arab information is often
more confident than exact.

Isa gestures to the wall of framed portraits behind them -
British officials. One temporary authority after another.

SHEIKH ISA
Each time I come to speak for Bahrain,
there is another British face. Another
man who assures me he understands.
Another man to whom I must answer.

Isa removes a sealed letter from his robe and hands it to Ross.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
Perhaps it is time I addressed someone
less temporary.

Ross looks at the envelope. His expression changes.

ROSS
This is for Her Majesty?

DALY
That really won't be necessary, Your
Honour.

SHEIKH ISA
Perhaps Her Majesty is best suited to
decide that.

Sheikh Ahmed allows himself the faintest smile. Isa turns and
leaves. Ahmed follows.

The British remain, staring at the letter with dread.

45 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD & GARDEN - DAY**

45

ISA plays with toy horses with his young sons, SALMAN (8) and
HAMAD (6) as SALEM BIN HAMAD confers with him.

MAJEED takes notes, while AHMED keeps an ear on the conversation
while tending to his beloved Frangipani tree.

SALEM BIN HAMAD
Support grows for the canals and
water distribution -

SHEIKHA HAYA (29) watches from a doorway, amused.

SHEIKHA HAYA
Salman. Hamad. Come. Let your father
speak with your uncles.

SHEIKH ISA
They are not bothering us, Haya.

SHEIKHA HAYA
But it is time for their lessons.

She gathers the boys and leads them away.

SALEM BIN HAMAD
Medicine remains a problem. Quinine
is often stolen before it reaches
those who need it.

SHEIKH AHMED
I have thought much on the pirate
threat.

They turn to him.

SHEIKH ISA
Always tending to that tree, Ahmed.
Why does it never bloom?

SHEIKH AHMED
I live in hope.

Ahmed puts down the water-tin and crosses to them.

SHEIKH AHMED (CONT'D)
Our father trusted family networks. If
Bahrain is to see clearly, she must
look through more eyes than our own.

SALEM BIN HAMAD
Whose eyes?

SHEIKH AHMED
Pearl-divers. Boatmen. Traders.
Fishermen who know which shore
receives strange sails by night.
Women who hear what men dismiss in
their presence.

Sheikh Isa nods slowly.

SHEIKH ISA
The country listening to itself.

SHEIKH AHMED
And protecting itself.

SHEIKH ISA
Khalil survives because he is treated
as a shadow, when he is only a man.

SHEIKH AHMED
And if one man can be found -

SHEIKH ISA
Others can be frightened into
stopping.

SALEM BIN HAMAD
A sound plan. Certainly better than
leaving it to the British.

SHEIKH ISA
Majeed. Let it be known. Anyone with
useful information will be handsomely
rewarded.

Majeed looks up from his notes -

MAJEED
Immediately, Your Honour.

46 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / LIBRARY - DAY**

46

HAYA sits on a low cushion with ZALAIKHA and the CHILDREN
gathered around her. An open book rests in her lap.

Haya guides Hamad's finger along the line.

SHEIKHA HAYA
Slowly. Let the word come to you.

Hamad sounds it out.

HAMAD
Children... are...

SHEIKHA HAYA
Good.

SALMAN
(finishes proudly)
Our hearts walking before us.

ZALAIKHA
These are beautiful words, Sheikha.

SHEIKHA HAYA
They belong to Hattem Al-Tayyi.

She turns the book gently toward Zalaikha.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)
Now you.

Zalaikha stiffens, embarrassed.

ZALAIKHA
My Sheikha, I cannot.

SHEIKHA HAYA
Your son is growing quickly. If you
learn, you can teach him.

Zalaikha nods, smiling.

SHEIKH ISA (O.S.)
You have filled my library with
scholars.

All look to - ISA watching from the doorway. He has heard enough
to understand.

SHEIKHA HAYA
I can only do so much.
(smiles knowingly)
It would be better if we could employ
a teacher.

Haya waits, sensing his mind moving.

SHEIKH ISA
But why only one? You could invite
learned men and women. Begin literary
salons. Places of reading. Poetry.
Letters. Instruction.

Haya listens, respectful, but gently corrects him.

SHEIKHA HAYA
Schools would be better. Not only
salons for those already near books.
Schools for children who have never
seen one.

The word lands. Isa smiles.

SHEIKH ISA
Schools. Yes.

SHEIKHA HAYA
A wonderful idea, my Sheikh.

He looks at her with a cheeky smile.

SHEIKH ISA
A wonderful idea indeed. I am
pleased I nearly thought of it.

Haya allows herself the smallest smile.

47 **EXT. MANAMA STREETS - NIGHT / DREAM**

47

Sheikh Isa walks alone through sleeping Manama.

Lantern light. Empty alleys. The hush of a city that trusts him
enough to sleep.

Then a figure at the far end of the street stands motionless.

The MASKED MAN.

Isa stops. He backs into shadow, pulse quickening in spite of
himself.

He turns a corner. Walks faster. Another corner. When he looks
back, the figure is closer.

Isa slips through a narrow lane and emerges into a small square.

Empty. No figure. Then -

He's there - mask removed - No mouth, no eyes. NO FACE.

48 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / BED CHAMBER - NIGHT**

48

Isa wakes, terrified -

The room is still. Only a hanging lantern swings gently in the
night breeze.

49 **EXT. TREE OF LIFE - DAWN**

49

The desert is vast and still beneath the early light.

The TREE stands alone against the emptiness, its branches stirring
in the evening wind.

SHEIKH ISA kneels beneath it, head bowed. For a long moment, he says nothing. Then, quietly –

SHEIKH ISA
Father. I try to honour you.

He looks up at the ancient branches above him.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
I try to be the ruler you would want
me to be.
(A beat)
You told us to keep our eyes on the
future. But what am I meant to see?

Silence. The impossible tree breathes above him – alive in a place where nothing should live.

Isa waits. Still nothing.

50 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD - MORNING**

50

ISA rides into the courtyard as MAJEED runs to him, breathless.

MAJEED
Forgive me, Your Honour.

As Isa dismounts.

MAJEED (CONT'D)
We've found a path to Khalil.

51 **EXT. FISHING VILLAGE/DOCK - NIGHT**

51

ISA waits with AHMED, MAJEED and two trusted MEN. A narrow dock stretches into black water. A few oil lamps burn low, their light trembling in the sea wind. The village sleeps behind them.

A small boat knocks against the dock. A figure climbs out.

BAMEI steps into the lamplight. One hand beneath her cloak.

Ahmed's hand moves to his sword. She notices.

BAMEI
If I wanted you dead, Sheikh Isa, I
would not come alone.

SHEIKH ISA
What do we call you?

BAMEI

Bamei.

(steps closer)

I offer a simple exchange. I'll
give you Khalil. For Passage.
Silver. And no British rope around
my neck when it's done.

SHEIKH AHMED

Why do you help us?

BAMEI

Because Khalil knows I know too much.

(a beat)

And because I prefer to be paid by men
who might keep their word.

SHEIKH ISA

First, you tell me what you know.

BAMEI

First, you promise.

SHEIKH ISA

If your information is true, you will
have passage, payment, and my word
that no British hand touches you.

BAMEI

Your word is worth more than theirs?

SHEIKH ISA

In Bahrain, yes.

Accepting, she removes a scrap of sailcloth from within her
cloak. She lays it on a crate. A rough map drawn in charcoal.

BAMEI

Tomorrow night. After moonrise. Khalil
will strike a merchant dhow here.

She taps the map.

BAMEI (CONT'D)

He will burn one boat, take the cargo
from another, then run through this
channel before dawn.

SHEIKH AHMED

Beyond the reef.

BAMEI

Yes. That is where he always escapes.
His men know the shallows. Your men
cannot follow fast enough.

SHEIKH ISA

But a British ship can wait beyond
them.

Isa folds the map.

BAMEI

If Khalil sees me before tomorrow
night, your trap dies with me.

SHEIKH ISA

Then do not be seen.

BAMEI

That is what I do best.

She climbs into the boat and rows back into the dark. Ahmed
watches her vanish.

SHEIKH AHMED

Do you believe the British can be
moved?

Isa looks down at the map in his hand.

SHEIKH ISA

I hope they won't have a choice.

52 **INT. BALMORAL CASTLE, SCOTLAND - MORNING**

52

QUEEN VICTORIA (50) walks slowly along the garden path, a parasol
held above her head. Beside her walks JOHN BROWN (50s) solid and
watchful, carrying a small leather dispatch case. He removes a
letter sealed with care.

JOHN BROWN

A letter from the ruler of Bahrain,
Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

Bahrain.

She considers the name with interest.

QUEEN VICTORIA (CONT'D)

I have often wished to see it. Islands
of pearls, is it not? And seas within
seas.

JOHN BROWN
So I am told, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA
The late ruler was a man of noble character. His son now rules, does he not? What is his name again?

JOHN BROWN
Sheikh Isa, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA
Yes. Sheikh Isa. Well, don't just stand there, Mr. Brown. Read it.

Brown opens the letter.

JOHN BROWN
(Reading)
"Your Royal Highness, Queen Victoria, Sovereign of Great Britain and Ireland, whose name travels farther than even your ships..."

QUEEN VICTORIA
(eyebrow raised)
Does it indeed?

JOHN BROWN
"Heaven has placed us far apart, yet your officers have placed themselves very near, and therefore I take the liberty of writing to the source from which their promises descend."

Brown clears his throat, uncertain.

QUEEN VICTORIA
Go on, Mr Brown.

JOHN BROWN
"Your Majesty's representatives assure me Britain desires peace in the Gulf. I am grateful for peace. My people are extremely fond of peace. We would enjoy it even more if pirates did not keep interrupting it."

QUEEN VICTORIA
Oh, he is bold.

JOHN BROWN
Very bold, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

Continue.

JOHN BROWN

"Bahrain has been patient with your residents and their delays, respectful of their explanations, and impressed by the number of Englishmen required to say very little. But while -"

The Queen snatches the letter from Brown.

QUEEN VICTORIA

(commences to read)

"But while papers move, ships burn. I ask that promises made in Britain's name be made real in Bahrain's waters. My father believed friendship between rulers must mean more than fine language."

She stops. Turns to Brown.

QUEEN VICTORIA (CONT'D)

Can you believe he would have the audacity to write such a letter?

JOHN BROWN

I surely can't, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

(continues to read)

"Therefore I ask - with the urgency of a man who has very little use for false humility - that Your Majesty instruct your government to act against Khalil, to protect our trade, and to ensure that Britain's friendship is known to Bahrain not merely by its flag, but by its deeds. There is no honour in a great empire being outpaced by a pirate."

She lowers the letter. Then she laughs, genuine, surprised.

QUEEN VICTORIA (CONT'D)

It's rather excellent.

JOHN BROWN

Ma'am?

QUEEN VICTORIA

Excellent. Impertinent, certainly. But excellent. He writes like a man who expects to be answered.

JOHN BROWN

That may be the intention.

QUEEN VICTORIA

Of course it is the intention. That is what makes it interesting.

She reads a line silently, then smiles again.

QUEEN VICTORIA (CONT'D)

Little use for false humility. Ha!

(beat)

Take a letter, Mr Brown. No. Make that a telegram.

53 **INT. BRITISH HMS TEAZER / OFFICE - DAY**

53

SHEIKH ISA and SHEIKH AHMED stand before COLONEL ROSS, CAPTAIN STEWART, and DALY. A map of Bahrain's waters lies open on the table. Isa points to a narrow passage beyond the reef.

SHEIKH ISA

Khalil strikes here tomorrow night.

Captain Stewart studies the map. Ross remains guarded.

ROSS

A British vessel cannot be moved on rumour.

SHEIKH ISA

Then call it an opportunity.

DALY

Or a trap.

SHEIKH AHMED

For Khalil, yes.

SHEIKH ISA

Our men will drive him from the shore. He will flee the way he always does - to the sea. That is where you stop him.

CAPTAIN STEWART

If he changes course?

SHEIKH ISA

Then he changes course into us.

Ross and Stewart exchange a look: not yet persuaded.

ROSS

Your Honour, cooperation of this kind requires certainty.

SHEIKH ISA

No, Colonel. It requires will.

(beat)

I trust there will be no lack of cooperation.

ROSS

Without the correct approvals, I'm afraid there is little -

BRITISH ASSISTANT (O.S.)

Sir. An urgent telegram.

A BRITISH ASSISTANT at the door holds a sealed envelope.

BRITISH ASSISTANT (CONT'D)

From Her Highness.

The room stills. Ross extends a hand.

ROSS

Give it to me.

The assistant hesitates.

BRITISH ASSISTANT

It is for Sheikh Isa, sir.

A small silence. Sheikh Ahmed lowers his eyes to hide his amusement. Ross's face drops before his hand does.

The assistant crosses to Isa and gives him the letter.

Isa opens it carefully and reads in silence. A faint smile.

Daly cannot bear it.

DALY

Well? What does she say?

Isa folds the letter with exquisite care.

SHEIKH ISA

The Queen kindly thanks me for my letter.

(MORE)

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

She says her representatives are to
give Bahrain every proper assistance.

Sheikh Ahmed smiles.

Isa looks from Ross to Stewart to Daly.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I imagine that means you? She also
says, if necessary, I am to remind you
that you work for her.

Ahmed unable to contain himself, laughs briefly. The British stand
chastened. Isa returns the letter to his robe.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Tomorrow night then?

54 **EXT. FISHING VILLAGE - NIGHT**

54

Moonlight over black water. A MERCHANT DHOW moves slowly against
a mooring, heavy with false cargo.

ISA watches with AHMED, from two small boats hidden beneath the
dock, with a dozen Bahraini fighters. More men hide on the dock.

A low whistle cuts through the night. One of Isa's scouts on
shore. Dark boats glide toward the dhow.

PIRATES. Their boats appear from darkness, beyond the reef.

Fast. Silent. Certain. At their head: KHALIL. He stands in the
prow, eyes fixed on the prize. The pirates hook the dhow and
climb aboard. No resistance. Then Khalil steps onto the deck.

KHALIL

Take the cargo. Burn the rest.

The dock erupts. Isa's men leap from their hiding spots and
attack. Steel flashes. Pirates fall. A torch is kicked into the
sea before it can touch the sail.

KHALIL (CONT'D)

Back! To the boats!

The pirates break for their craft.

SHEIKH ISA

He's running!

Isa and his men give chase in their boats - but the pirates'
craft are too fast.

Across the water, Isa sees Khalil. For one charged moment, they face each other. Then Khalil smiles, raises a pistol. BLAM!

All on Isa's boat duck low. The shot whizzes past harmlessly.

Khalil's men row harder. The boat tears away toward the channel beyond the reef – the same escape route he has always used.

Khalil looks back at Isa with triumph.

Then – A CANNON FLASH splits the night. The sea beside Khalil's skiff erupts. Out of the darkness looms a BRITISH WARSHIP. CAPTAIN STEWART stands on deck.

54A EXT. BRITISH WARSHIP - DECK

54A

CAPTAIN STEWART

Fire across the bow! Drive him back!

Another cannon blast. Too close. The shot throws up a wall of water in front of Khalil's skiff, but also scatters Isa's pursuing boats. Men duck, shout, lose their oars.

SHEIKH AHMED

They are blocking us!

Isa sees it at once. The British have not trapped Khalil. They have opened the wrong side of the channel. Khalil sees it too.

KHALIL

There! Row!

His men swing the skiff hard toward the gap. On the British warship, Stewart misunderstands the movement.

CAPTAIN STEWART

Hold fire! He is turning back!

But Khalil is not turning back. He is slipping past them. A British boat drops too late, splashing clumsily into the water. Sailors fumble with oars in the dark.

CAPTAIN STEWART (CONT'D)

Cut him off!

Too late. Khalil's skiff shoots through the open channel toward his waiting ship beyond the reef.

Isa's men try to follow, but the churn from the cannon fire and the British boats has broken their line.

Ahmed's boat surges forward – then another cannon blast lands close enough to force them back.

SHEIKH AHMED

They will kill our own men!

Isa turns toward the British warship, fury controlled only by discipline.

On the far water, Khalil reaches his ship. Ropes drop. Hands haul him aboard. For one final moment, Khalil stands at the rail. Then his ship turns into darkness.

CAPTAIN STEWART

Damn it. Signal pursuit!

But the British vessel is too large for the reef channel. It turns slowly, uselessly, while Khalil disappears into the night.

SHEIKH AHMED

The British have cost us the Butcher.

He coughs once. Then again. The cough catches deep in his chest. Isa watches the black water where Khalil vanished.

55 **INT. BRITISH HMS TEAZER / OFFICE - DAY**

55

ROSS sits behind his desk. DALY stands to the side, watchful. Ross wears the patient expression of an official withstanding complaint. SHEIKH ISA and SHEIKH AHMED stand before them.

SHEIKH ISA

Captain Stewart's guns scattered my boats and opened the channel.

ROSS

Captain Stewart made an error in difficult conditions.

SHEIKH AHMED

An error that allowed Khalil's escape.

DALY

The engagement was confused. Night, shallow water. Easy to mis-judge.

SHEIKH ISA

I judged properly. I watched British cannon fire drive my men from the man they came to catch.

ROSS

No one here takes satisfaction in his errors. Stewart has been reprimanded and will be reassigned.

SHEIKH ISA
Reports. Reprimands. Transfers.
Words arranged until failure
becomes procedure.

SHEIKH AHMED
So the mistake leaves on the next
ship, and the pirate remains.

ROSS
This is a serious implication.

SHEIKH ISA
Bahrain cannot be protected by men
who do not know our reefs, do not
trust our boats, and do not suffer
our dead.

DALY
Her Majesty's policy remains peace,
trade, and order.

SHEIKH ISA
Her Majesty should be told what
those words become on our coast.

Ross and Daly hold their silence.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
Fear asks for protection. Trade
accepts control. A frightened
country is easier to manage.

Isa heads for the door without another word. Ahmed follows.

56 **EXT. MANAMA PORT - DAY**

56

A British vessel prepares to depart. CAPTAIN STEWART stands on
deck, stiff with humiliation. Reassigned. Removed.

On the quay, Sheikh Isa and Sheikh Ahmed watch.

Stewart sees them. For a brief moment, his eyes meet Isa's. Not
guilt. Warning. Then he turns away as the gangplank is lifted.

SHEIKH AHMED
There is the failure they could
afford to punish.

The ship begins to pull from the quay.

SHEIKH AHMED (CONT'D)

We should have captured Khalil
ourselves.

SHEIKH ISA

Stewart may have meant to help.

SHEIKH AHMED

Because their Queen demanded it.
What the others wanted is seemingly
more important.

SHEIKH ISA

A man may be trustworthy. The
system is another creature.

SHEIKH AHMED

Then stop feeding the creature.

SHEIKH ISA

Bahrain cannot make an enemy of
every hand not its own.

SHEIKH AHMED

No. But we should stop pretending
every hand offered is open.

The cough catches in Ahmed's chest. He turns away, covering it.
It passes. Not quickly enough.

SHEIKH ISA

You must go to the hospital in
Baghdad.

SHEIKH AHMED

For a cough?

SHEIKH ISA

A cough that gets worse. You make
me worry.

SHEIKH AHMED

You worry too much, my brother. And
not always about the right things.
Khalil will return. It is only a
matter of how long.

Isa, troubled, watches Ahmed go.

57 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / SHEIKH ISA'S PRAYER ROOM - DAY - 1932**

NOURA

So you did not vanquish the pirates,
Grandfather?

SHEIKH ISA

No. Khalil went into hiding. The
others scattered.

NOURA

But the burden remained.

SHEIKH ISA

Yes. And soon a greater one would
come.

(beat)

But burdens and blessings sometimes
arrive together. That was when Aisha
came into my life.

Noura's face brightens.

NOURA

My grandmother!

SHEIKH ISA

Yes, sweet Noura. Your grandmother.

NOURA

Then I welcome this part of the story.

SHEIKH ISA

As did I. Aisha was truly my blessing.

His smile fades.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Though that same day brought
something I had prayed never to
see.

58 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD GARDEN - DAY.**

58

SUPER: MANAMA - 1888

Ahmed (now 40s) tends to his Frangipani tree - still without
bloom. He looks unwell. Slow, congested breathing, pale skin.

He goes to lift the water-tin, it slips from his hand and falls
to the ground. Water absorbs into the thirsty soil.

59 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / LIBRARY - CONTINUOUS**

59

SHEIKHA HAYA (Late 30s) sits with AISHA (Late 20s) composed, intelligent, and unmistakably accustomed to rooms of authority. Books, account papers, and children's teaching materials rest on a low table between them.

SHEIKH ISA (40s) enters. Haya rises.

SHEIKHA HAYA
My Sheikh.

Aisha rises also and lowers her head respectfully.

AISHA
Your Honour.

SHEIKHA HAYA
This is Aisha. I interviewed her this morning for one of the teaching posts.

Isa looks at Aisha with recognition.

SHEIKH ISA
I know who she is.

Aisha meets this with quiet composure.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
A woman of royal blood does not usually present herself for such work.

AISHA
Then perhaps such work has been undervalued, Your Honour.

SHEIKHA HAYA
She is more than qualified.

SHEIKH ISA
So why work as a teacher?

AISHA
Because children are where a country begins.
(a beat)
And because a woman may enter a room more easily as a teacher than as counsel.

SHEIKH ISA
Counsel?

Aisha glances briefly to Haya. Haya gives the smallest nod: Speak.

AISHA

I came for the teaching post, Your Honour. But I would ask for another position. That of counsellor.

SHEIKH ISA

To whom?

AISHA

To the palace. To the women who come here seeking settlement. To families divided by inheritance, marriage, children, reputation. Matters that do not begin in the majlis. They begin behind doors. I am qualified. And capable.

SHEIKH ISA

That role is traditionally undertaken by men.

HAYA

Men often hear these troubles after pride has ruined them. Women hear them earlier. Before they become wounds.

Haya watches Isa, quietly pleased by the answer.

SHEIKH ISA

And you believe tradition permits this?

AISHA

Tradition is not a locked room, Your Honour. Khadija was the Prophet's partner in trade and in courage. She was not ornamental to his life. She strengthened it.

SHEIKH ISA

You have studied widely.

AISHA

I was fortunate in my upbringing. Books were not treated as decoration.

A glance to the materials on the table.

AISHA (CONT'D)

I was taught accounts, letters, poetry, law, and the management of a household large enough to resemble a small state.

A faint smile from Haya.

SHEIKH ISA
And what did that teach you?

AISHA
That a household fails for the same
reasons a country fails. Unpaid debts.
Bad counsel. Silence where truth is
needed.

Isa watches her with clear admiration.

SHEIKH ISA
And what do you think of the British?

AISHA
We must study them. Their history.
Their habits. Their laws. What they
call order. What they call progress.
What they call protection.

She lets that sit.

AISHA (CONT'D)
If Bahrain is to deal with such men,
we must understand the shape of their
thinking before it is used against us.

Isa's expression changes.

SHEIKH ISA
My father told me I should study with
the British. Once, long ago.

AISHA
Then your father understood that
courage alone would not be enough.

The words land with precision. Haya sees it. Isa studies Aisha
with new respect. He looks to Haya.

SHEIKH ISA
You have brought me a formidable mind,
Haya.

Haya gives the smallest nod. She smiles.

Suddenly yelling from the garden -

60 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD GARDEN - CONTINUOUS**

60

SHEIKH ISA and SHEIKHA HAYA hurry out into the garden. AISHA follows, but holds back in the doorway, sensing this is not her place to enter.

Across the garden, two SERVANTS are tending to SHEIKH AHMED, who lies on the ground. AHMED'S WIFE rushes to Haya.

AHMED'S WIFE

My husband!

She falls into Haya's arms, sobbing.

Isa freezes for the smallest instant. Then he goes to Ahmed. The servants look up as Isa kneels beside his brother.

Isa knows. It is already too late.

61 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / SHEIKH AHMED'S ROOM - DAY**

61

Sheikh Ahmed lies on his bed, gaunt and still. Sheikh Isa kneels by the bed. Salem Bin Hamad stands nearby, shaken. He gives Isa a look of deep condolence, then quietly withdraws.

In the hall, Haya holds Ahmed's wife as she sobs against her.

Majeed stands nearby, devastated, unable to speak.

Isa reaches for Ahmed's hand and takes it in both his. The hand is already cooling. Isa bows his head over it.

He has lost his brother. His greatest confidante. His friend.

SHEIKH ISA

Forgive me.

On Ahmed's wrist rests his distinctive tasbeeh prayer beads. With great care, Isa removes the beads from Ahmed's hand. Holds them a moment. Then places them around his own wrist.

MAJEED

I am sorry, Your Honour.

Isa does not open his eyes.

MAJEED (CONT'D)

Typhoid. Without medicine, nothing could be done.

Isa's hand tightens around the prayer beads.

MAJEED (CONT'D)

The British promised... The last shipment did not come.

The sorrow in Isa's face hardens into something else. Rage. Abruptly he stands and pushes past Majeed -

62 **EXT. TREE OF LIFE - SUNSET**

62

A thunder of hooves, as Isa drives his horse toward the TREE OF LIFE ahead of him. Like he's charging an enemy.

He pulls up violently. The horse rears. Isa throws himself from the saddle, stumbling onto his knees.

Grief breaks through him. His fists in the sand.

SHEIKH ISA

Father... You left me a sword.

He draws his father's sword. Rises unsteadily.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

But Ahmed... Ahmed was my shield. You told me to look to the future.

He swings the sword at the empty air. Again. Harder.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I look, and it is blood.

Another savage cut through the wind.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I build, and death comes.

He slashes at nothing. At the British. At Khalil. At typhoid. At himself.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I hold one thing together and another is torn from me!

He turns on the space around him, striking again and again until the sword is no longer a weapon but an argument with the world.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

You brought me here as a boy. You spoke of unseen water. Of dreams beneath the sand.

He steps closer to the trunk, trembling with rage.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

What do you want from me?

He strikes the air beside the Tree, stopping short of the living wood. Even in fury, he cannot wound it.

He drops to one knee, breath ragged.

The sun dies behind the horizon. As Isa remains beneath the Tree, alone with the weight of all he has inherited.

63 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD - EVENING / DREAM**

63

ISA watches AHMED tend his frangipani tree. Both young men again.

The tree in full blossom. White flowers stir in the evening wind. Ahmed turns to Isa and smiles. Then his smile fades. Beyond the tree, at the far edge of the courtyard -

A FIGURE. Still. Masked. Watching.

Isa stiffens.

The Masked Man moves. Too fast.

Ahmed falls before Isa can reach him. Isa cries out, but no sound comes. Ahmed is gone. The courtyard is empty. Isa turns -

The Masked Man stands directly behind him. Impossibly close.

Isa recoils, hand flying to his sword. Steel flashes free.

The Masked Man lunges. Isa strikes. Again. Again. The blade tears through robes, shadow, air - but never flesh.

The Masked Man collapses inward, vanishing into himself. His black robes fall empty to the ground. Only the mask remains.

Isa stands over it, chest heaving. Slowly, he kneels and lifts the mask. Behind it: nothing. No face. No man.

Only darkness.

64 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / BED CHAMBER - FIRST LIGHT**

64

Isa wakes violently. He sits up, breathing hard. For a moment, he does not know where he is.

65 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD GARDEN - CONTINUOUS**

65

The palace garden lies still in the faint glow of dawn. ISA alone, shaken from sleep, trying to steady himself.

SHEIKHA HAYA (O.S.)

Isa.

HAYA in a doorway, wrapped against the chill.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

I heard you calling out in your sleep.

Haya crosses the garden and stands beside him.

SHEIKH ISA

Ahmed carried half my thinking.

(beat)

Without him, the past hunts me.

SHEIKHA HAYA

You do not have to carry it alone.

SHEIKH ISA

A ruler carries many things alone.

SHEIKHA HAYA

A ruler, perhaps. Not a husband.

Something catches Haya's eye. Near the courtyard wall:

Ahmed's frangipani tree stands in the early light. Its branches are covered in pale blossoms. Haya is struck silent.

He follows her gaze. The frangipani has bloomed. Finally. The beauty of it is too cruel.

Haya reaches the tree, careful not to touch the flowers.

Isa arrives beside her, staring at the blossoms.

SHEIKH ISA

Not once in his life. Not ever. Why now?

A soft wind moves through the flowers.

SHEIKHA HAYA

We keep living. We keep growing. Even when the one who planted us is gone. This tree did not bloom when Ahmed begged it to. It did not bloom because he was patient, or because he deserved to see it.

(MORE)

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

(a beat)

It blooms now because life keeps its
own time.

Isa closes his eyes, breathing slowly.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

Ride slower, my Sheikh. You cannot
catch life by chasing it harder.

A faint echo of another time. He looks back at the frangipani
blossoms. Beautiful. Alive.

66 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / RAMPARTS - DAWN**

66

A sweeping view across Manama and the harbour. The coast we once
saw through young Isa's eyes – now grown, prosperous, crowded with
dhows, warehouses, lamps burning to life.

SUPER: MANAMA/BAHRAIN 1893

SHEIKH SALMAN (20) stands at the parapet, dressed for departure.
SHEIKH ISA (45), older now but still commanding, approaches.

SHEIKH ISA (O.S.)

Salman.

Salman turns.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

A last look before Mecca?

SHEIKH SALMAN

So I remember it properly. All that
you've built.

Isa joins him at the parapet.

SHEIKH ISA

I have played my part. That is all.
As you will.

Isa looks back across Bahrain.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Just yesterday you were a child in my
arms. Now you go to the House of God.

(a beat)

My heart will yearn for your return.
As too will your mother's and
brother's.

SHEIKH SALMAN
You will all be in my prayers.

SHEIKH ISA
May your first Hajj and prayers be
accepted.

Salman bows his head.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
After your pilgrimage, we begin
preparing. For the day Bahrain
looks to you.

He places a hand on Salman's shoulder.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
You listen before you speak. Men do
not feel diminished in your presence.
That is rarer than courage.

Salman absorbs the weight of it.

SHEIKH SALMAN
May I prove worthy of what you built.

SHEIKH ISA
That is all a father can ask.

67 **EXT. PORT MANAMA - DAY**

67

A STEAMER pulls in.

Passengers disembark into the heat and noise of the port. Among
them is PRATAP (80s) weathered and dignified.

Isa, Hamad, and Majeed wait on the dock.

Pratap bows respectfully to Isa, then to Hamad.

PRATAP
Your Honour. Sheikh Hamad.

SHEIKH ISA
Pratap, it's been too long. I am told
you've come all the way from Bombay
with purpose.

PRATAP
At my age, Your Honour, a man learns
not to travel without it.

Isa is intrigued.

PRATAP (CONT'D)

In Bombay, I met a Frenchman whose family appreciates luxury better than most.

SHEIKH ISA

A merchant?

PRATAP

More than a merchant. A man who understands desire, which is often more profitable. He may open doors the British prefer to keep locked.

Isa smiles faintly.

PRATAP (CONT'D)

I hoped to introduce him to you.

SHEIKH ISA

Then let him come. And let him prove he is worth receiving.

PRATAP

I was almost certain you would say that, Your Honour.

A commotion at the top of the gangplank.

PRATAP (CONT'D)

Ah. Here he comes now.

JACQUES CARTIER, 28, descends the gangplank in pale European linen, gloves, polished shoes, and absolute confidence.

Behind him, four EUROPEAN ASSISTANTS struggle with trunks, cases, and hat boxes – far too much luggage for a Bahraini port.

Isa watches the procession with amusement.

SHEIKH ISA

I see you were quite certain, Pratap.

PRATAP

Erm, yes...

(clears throat)

Your Honour, may I introduce Monsieur Jacques Cartier.

Cartier steps onto the quay, slips slightly, and recovers with practiced dignity.

SHEIKH ISA

Monsieur Cartier. Welcome to Bahrain.

CARTIER

Thank you, Your Honour. I have come to see if the pearls here are truly worth the journey.

SHEIKH ISA

And Bahrain will decide whether you are.

Cartier is caught off guard.

CARTIER

Excuse me?

SHEIKH HAMAD

You bring much luggage.

CARTIER

Tools of the trade, Your Honour.

Hamad eyes the trunks.

SHEIKH ISA

Come then, Monsieur Cartier. If you wish to deal in pearls, you should first meet the sea that makes them.

CARTIER

I shall be delighted, Your Honour.

68 **EXT. OFF THE BAHRAIN COAST - DAY**

68

A dhow rocks gently on clear blue water. Pearl banks shimmer beneath the surface.

On deck: ISA, HAMAD, MAJEED, PRATAP, and CARTIER with his team.

Cartier is being fitted into a full diving suit – thick canvas, weighted boots, brass fittings. Beside him stands a steel spherical helmet with thick glass viewing ports.

Nearby, Cartier's men work a MECHANICAL BREATHING PUMP bolted awkwardly to the deck, with hoses coiled like sea serpents.

Hamad examines the machine, fascinated.

SHEIKH HAMAD

Look at this, Father. Insulated fittings. Synthetic material. For electrical uses, radios, even jewellery, they say.

CARTIER
Jewellery? Never!

PRATAP
Bakelite. I hear it lasts forever.

Sheikh Isa considers this.

SHEIKH ISA
Forever is a dangerous promise.

Cartier's team fastens the last buckles.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
And all this is necessary?

CARTIER
If I am to breathe underwater, yes.

SHEIKH ISA
Bahraini divers merely learn to
hold our breath.

CARTIER
This is better. Allow me to show you.

The men lower the helmet over Cartier's head. His face appears
behind the glass – suddenly small.

The pump begins its steady rhythm. HISS. CREAK. HISS. CREAK.

Cartier gives an uncertain thumbs-up.

Sheikh Isa nods to his own divers.

Two BAHRAINI DIVERS slip over the side, graceful.

Cartier takes a step off the boat's side – with a large splash –

His team feeds the hose carefully.

68A **UNDERWATER**

68A

Cartier sinks. FAST. In a cloud of silver bubbles, ungainly in
the heavy suit. The weights around his waste drag him downwards
faster than the boots and –

He HITS the bottom arse-first, in a cloud of silt.

The Bahraini divers glide past him like creatures born to the sea.

Cartier, stands, steadies himself. Then he sees it.

The pearl beds.

Shells scattered across the seabed. Light rippling over coral.
Fish cutting through shafts of sun.

The world beneath Bahrain. Quiet. Vast. Alive.

A diver lifts a shell and places it in Cartier's gloved hand.

Cartier stares through the glass, awestruck.

69 **EXT. DHOW - DAY - MOMENTS LATER**

69

Cartier is hauled back aboard. The helmet is removed. He gasps in the open air, face flushed, transformed.

CARTIER

Mon Dieu.

SHEIKH ISA

You came to see pearls.

The diver places a shell in Isa's hand. Isa gives it to Cartier.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Now you have seen where they begin.

Cartier looks at the shell as if it were sacred.

PRATAP

Bahrain is persuasive beneath the water.

Cartier laughs, still catching his breath.

CARTIER

My friend, I have seen the mind of God.

70 **EXT. BAB AL-BAHRAIN / HARBOUR ADJACENT SOUK - MANAMA - DAY**

70

A thriving marketplace. Spice, silk, copper, pearls. Traders from across the Gulf and beyond. Boys carry tea through the crowd. The call to prayer drifts above commerce without interrupting it.

Isa walks with Hamad, Salem Bin Hamad, Yusuf Kanoo, Saad Al Hazzani, Pratap, and Cartier.

SHEIKH ISA

Look around you, Monsieur Cartier.
Arabs, Persians, Indians, Jews.
Divers, merchants, shipbuilders,
blacksmiths.

(MORE)

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Different sects, faiths, languages,
blood – all passing through the same
market.

CARTIER

You have made a place where many
worlds can stand beside each other
without drawing knives.

Bicycles weave through the crowds. Traders call out. Scales CLANG
as coins are weighed. Fruit, nuts, spices, cloth, pearls.

Cartier pauses often, delighted by details.

A vendor hands coloured ice treats to children.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

Popsicles! Even here.

SAAD AL HAZZANI

Refrigeration, Monsieur Cartier.
When I first read of it, I told
Sheikh Isa immediately.

PRATAP

In Bombay, even the heat has begun to
fear machines.

CARTIER

Bahrain has some use for modern
devices, after all.

SHEIKH ISA

Progress has many faces, Monsieur
Cartier.

Hazzani spots a spare bicycle leaning nearby.

SAAD AL HAZZANI

And this – a recent import.

He climbs onto it with great confidence and very little skill.

SAAD AL HAZZANI (CONT'D)

I am yet to master it.

He pedals forward, wobbling badly through the crowd. For one
alarming moment he nearly topples into a basket of dates, then
catches himself at the last second.

PRATAP

I could not have said it better.

The group laughs as they continue through the souk. Cartier buys tobacco for his pipe.

SAAD AL HAZZANI

As you see, business here is good.

CARTIER

Yes. I see. Very good indeed.

71 **INT. THUKAIR'S HOME - DINING AREA - NIGHT**

71

A magnificent meal. Bowls of leben. A great platter of QUZI — whole lamb over rice, roasted chickens arranged around it. Salukis lounge at the doorway, dignified, waiting for scraps.

Around the feast sit ISA, HAMAD, SALEM BIN HAMAD, YUSUF KANOO, THUKAIR, PRATAP, and CARTIER.

PRATAP

Bombay may be my ancestral home. Where
I find peace, trade, and enough noise
to keep an old man feeling young.

(beat)

But Bahrain... Bahrain is different.

He looks to Cartier.

PRATAP (CONT'D)

Its true treasures are its people.
That is what makes these pearls so
special.

Cartier glares excitedly at a bowl of pearls before him.

CARTIER

They are exceptional. Pure. Lustrous.
Unlike anything I have seen.

He takes several pearls from the bowl into his palm.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

I should like to show the world
that pearls from these waters are
beyond compare. And the jewellery.
The jewellery must remember the
life it came from.

He lifts his glass of water, studying the light through it.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

This water, sweet from your wells. The
sea a man must cross to reach you.

(MORE)

CARTIER (CONT'D)

Imagine a tiara like that – pearls
falling as though from a fountain. A
jewel that remembers the ocean.

The men listen. Cartier feels them with him.

PRATAP

That is what Bahraini pearls can be.
Not merely traded. Desired. First
Paris. Then London. Then every court
that wishes to be envied.

THUKAIR

What of Japanese cultivated pearls? Do
they concern you?

YUSUF KANOO

This man Mikimoto. They say he floods
Europe.

Cartier waves this away.

CARTIER

Mikimoto. Sch-Mikimoto. Cultivation
imitates what the sea creates. A
natural pearl is God's own
patience. Symmetry born from
struggle.

Cartier leans forward, lowers his voice.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

Tell me. I've heard talk across the
Gulf of a pearl unlike any other. Born
in darkness. Perfect as night.

SHEIKH ISA

The Black Pearl.

All eyes turn to Isa.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

When I was a boy, I searched for it.
Sadly, it does not exist.

CARTIER

No?

SHEIKH ISA

It is but a legend.

Cartier studies him.

CARTIER

A legend? Do you truly believe that?

Isa has no answer. The silence hangs.

PRATAP

Legends also travel well, Monsieur Cartier.

CARTIER

Perhaps legends do. Real pearls however require safe passage.

(looks to Isa)

Monsieur Pratap tells me Bahrain has dealt with the pirate threat.

SHEIKH ISA

The worst of it has passed.

YUSUF KANOO

Our ports are strong.

SALEM BIN HAMAD

And our captains stronger.

Cartier looks to Isa.

CARTIER

Then Bahrain's pearls can travel anywhere. If you agree, Your Honour.

SHEIKH ISA

Bahrain has never failed to recognise a tide turning toward her, Monsieur Cartier.

Cartier raises his glass.

CARTIER

Then I look forward to doing business with Bahrain very soon.

All acknowledge the toast. The deal has been done.

Cartier gestures to his PHOTOGRAPHER.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

Gentlemen, a photograph?

The men gather and compose themselves. Cartier adjusts his cuffs. Pratap sits proudly among them. Hamad stands beside Isa.

A FLASH of magnesium light fills the room.

MAJEED appears, crosses quietly to Isa and whispers in his ear.

Isa's expression darkens. As the others continue smiling for the photograph.

72 **INT. BRITISH HMS TEAZER / OFFICE - DAY**

72

COLONEL ROSS stands behind his desk, incredulous. DALY sits nearby, composed, almost amused. SHEIKH ISA faces them, controlled. HAMAD stands beside him, silent and watchful.

ROSS

You are being unreasonable, Your Honour.

SHEIKH ISA

I am asking for a British warship.

ROSS

You are asking for one British vessel to pursue another.

SHEIKH ISA

The one Khalil stole from you. Unless that fact is also too unreasonable to mention?

ROSS

It was not a warship of the line. It was a patrol vessel in port. Khalil raided by night. Two British soldiers were killed.

SHEIKH ISA

And now a pirate sails British guns through Bahraini waters.

DALY

Khalil has been seen near the outer channels. We are aware of the danger.

SHEIKH ISA

Then give me the means to end it.

DALY

A warship under your command?

SHEIKH ISA

Under my direction. He knows our reefs. So do we.

DALY

Perhaps you should leave capturing
Khalil to us, Your Honour?

SHEIKH ISA

I see. Like last time?

Daly's irritation shows.

DALY

The colonel and I have discussed
another option. This confirms why
Manama requires a political agent.

Ross comes around the desk now. No longer polite.

ROSS

A British officer on the ground.
Someone empowered to assess these
matters before they become demands for
warships.

DALY

A modern harbour cannot be governed by
instinct and family loyalty alone.

ROSS

British order keeps these waters open.

SHEIKH ISA

And yet Khalil now sails them with
British guns.

Isa sees the trap. They have turned his complaint against him.

ROSS

If Bahrain profits from the Gulf,
Bahrain must help maintain the system
that keeps it open.

SHEIKH ISA

So we rely on British protection that
does not protect us.

DALY

We maintain stability.

ROSS

And the agent will help ensure it.

SHEIKH ISA

As you serve your Queen, my family
serves me. We manage well enough.

Daly glances at Hamad.

DALY
This young man says very little.

HAMAD
All in good time.

SHEIKH ISA
Her Majesty need not wait so long for
my next letter. We've installed the
telegraph in Manama.

HAMAD
Progress is wonderful, is it not?

As Isa turns for the door -

SHEIKH ISA
Come, Hamad.

Hamad rushes after his father and they both exit. Silence.

DALY
He is a problem. Give him what he
wants.

ROSS
The ship?

DALY
Enough rope.

Ross looks toward the closed door.

73 **EXT. SEA OFF BAHRAIN - SUNRISE**

73

A low red sun burns across the water.

KHALIL'S STOLEN BRITISH WARSHIP rides heavy in the swell, patched
and scarred, its cannon mouths black with old fire.

A PIRATE, high in the rigging, spots something.

PIRATE
Khalil! A ship. Eastbound.

Khalil takes the spyglass.

Through it: a MERCHANT DHOW, slow and fat in the water. Cargo
stacked high. Too easy.

PIRATE (CONT'D)
Pearls, maybe.

Khalil smiles.

KHALIL
Then we take what God has sent us.

But beyond the dhow – hidden against the glare – another shape
gathers speed.

A BRITISH WARSHIP. Its sails full.

Its decks crowded with BAHRAINI FIGHTERS and British soldiers. A
British captain at the wheel.

At the bow stands SHEIKH ISA. Still as stone. Focused. Beside him,
HAMAD & MAJEED.

MAJEED
Your Honour, will it be no blood,
unless there is no choice?

Isa stares at the oncoming pirate ship. He raises his sword.

SHEIKH ISA
We must stop Khalil. With as few
lives lost as possible.

74 **EXT. KHALIL'S WARSHIP / DECK - SAME**

74

Khalil lowers the spyglass. The smile drains from his face.

KHALIL
Turn us.

Too late. The warship comes straight at them.

A full-frontal assault.

The Bahraini fighters roar.

75 **EXT. BRITISH WARSHIP / BOW - CONTINUOUS**

75

SHEIKH ISA
Brace!

The two ships SLAM together with a violent crack of timber. Hooks
fly. Ropes bite. Planks crash across the gap.

Isa is the first across.

76 **EXT. KHALIL'S WARSHIP / DECK - CONTINUOUS**

76

Isa knocks down the first pirate before he can lift his blade.

Hamad and the Bahraini fighters pour in behind him. The deck explodes into brutal combat.

Isa cuts a path through the chaos. A pirate lunges at him. Isa parries, drives an elbow into his face, hurls him aside. Another pirate swings low. Isa turns, slashes, keeps moving. His eyes are locked on one man.

Khalil. Backing away, drawing his curved blade.

Isa attacks. Their blades collide with savage force. Khalil is fast. Experienced. Cruel. He gives ground, then strikes back hard.

They fight across the deck, through smoke and bodies, past Hamad driving back a pirate of his own.

Khalil hooks Isa's blade, twists, tries to disarm him. Isa drives forward. A brutal exchange – blade against blade, hilt against jaw, boot against knee.

Khalil smashes Isa to the deck, Hamad goes after him.

Khalil attacks Hamad now. He's no match. Khalil slashes Hamad. Blood. The boy drops to the deck.

Isa yells in anger. Something darker takes hold.

Isa attacks with terrifying force now. Khalil can barely contain him. Isa batters his defence apart, blow by blow, until Khalil's blade flies from his hand and skids across the deck.

Khalil falls back against the mast. Isa's sword is at his throat. All around them, the battle collapses. Pirates drop their weapons. Bahraini fighters seize the deck.

Khalil looks up, breathing hard.

KHALIL

Do it. Kill me.

Isa's rage overtakes him. He raises the sword over his head to strike down on Khalil.

HAMAD

Father!

Hamad, bloodied but alive.

Isa's blade goes to the pirate's throat. He leans close.

SHEIKH ISA

You are fortunate my son lives.

Khalil breathes hard, pinned beneath him.

KHALIL

You should learn who to trust and who not, Sheikh Isa. I may be the face you blame, but there is another as guilty.

SHEIKH ISA

Who?

KHALIL

The one who tells the British to look away. Fear is the best weapon.

SHEIKH ISA

Ross.

Khalil smiles through blood.

Isa's guard slips.

That's all it takes. A hidden knife flashes from Khalil's sleeve. Aimed for Isa's throat -

BANG!

The shot cracks across the deck. Khalil's body snaps back against the mast. A bullet between the eyes. He drops dead.

Smoke curls from a British pistol. MAJEED stands nearby, arm extended, breathing hard.

Isa looks from Khalil's body to Majeed. He lowers the pistol.

MAJEED

Forgive me, Your Honour. There was no choice.

77 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / LIBRARY - DAY**

77

HAYA kneels before an arched window overlooking the sea, shattered. ZALAIKHA kneels beside her, trying to comfort her.

A NOTE, read and crushed in Haya's fist.

ISA enters. Still marked by battle - blood on his sleeve, salt on his robe, victory not yet settled in his face.

Zalaikha rises quickly, bows, hurries from the room.

SHEIKH ISA

Haya?

Her fingers tighten around the note.

SHEIKHA HAYA

You were not here.

Isa's blood runs cold. He shakes his head, refusing it.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

He was returning from Hajj. His pilgrimage was complete.

SHEIKH ISA

No.

SHEIKHA HAYA

He will go straight to Paradise,
Insha'Allah.

SHEIKH ISA

I do not believe you.

She holds out the note but doesn't stand.

SHEIKHA HAYA

Here.

He steps to her. She thrusts the open note toward him.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

Read it. Believe.

Isa takes it. He looks at the page just long enough to know.

SHEIKH ISA

Malaria...

Haya watches with unbearable pain.

SHEIKHA HAYA

Your son is dead. I had to learn it
without you.

He slumps to his knees beside her.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

We are losing those closest to us. And
I grieve alone. While you...

(beat)

You keep moving so sorrow cannot catch
you.

Isa turns away, wounded by the truth of it.

SHEIKHA HAYA (CONT'D)

I can do nothing more for you, Isa.

That strikes deeper than anger would.

Haya stands, walks past him - leaves without an embrace. Without another word.

The note trembles in Isa's hand, then drops to the floor.

78 **EXT. MANAMA STREETS / VARIOUS - EVENING**

78

The funeral procession for Sheikh Salman.

WOMEN with lanterns. Candles along the streets leading to the coast. Sailors and divers sit at the edge of their dhows, watching lights illuminate the water.

People from all communities offer solidarity. Rabbi Josef leads a procession of Jewish followers out from his synagogue.

Groups of Hindus and Christians pass the Shrinathji Temple. Oil lamps flicker along its stone steps, jasmine garlands hang from carved archways. The temple bells chime.

An inconsolable Haya leans on Zalaikha and other women from every community around her as they comfort her.

Isa watches from a distance. Alone. Stoic, solemn and with an ocean of grief reflected in his eyes.

79 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / RAMPARTS - NIGHT**

79

Isa alone, looks out over Manama, silent in the dark.

AISHA (O.S.)

I have been looking for you.

SHEIKH ISA

I was not seeking company.

AISHA

No.

(beat)

Only ghosts.

Aisha approaches, comes to his side. Her eyes catch moonlight.

SHEIKH ISA

I stood here when he left. We spoke of the future. Now all I see is what has been lost.

AISHA

The ones you lost before him will know how to receive him.

Isa closes his eyes.

SHEIKH ISA

Ahmed is gone. Salman is gone.

AISHA

But Hamad is here. Bahrain is here. And morning will come whether we are ready for it or not.

Isa looks back over Manama. This time, not only in sorrow.

AISHA (CONT'D)

We have waited long enough for the British. We need a hospital. Before disease takes another life.

(beat)

I have heard of American doctors willing to come to Bahrain.

Isa looks at Aisha with immense gratitude in his eyes.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Aisha could see the true path.

80 INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / LIBRARY - DAY

80

Sheikh Isa watches Aisha talking with a husband who is resistant to letting his daughter be educated.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

She knew life does not wait. Though we chase more slowly.

AISHA

Do you not see the opportunities that women have under Sheikh Isa? And still, you won't accept your daughter's right to an education.

The Husband hangs his head.

AISHA (CONT'D)

Deny your children, male or female
the right to learn and you deny
them of their future - and yours.

It's clear Isa is impressed by her. Something else is growing.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Aisha entered my house as counsel.

81 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD - DAY**

81

The courtyard is dressed for ceremony. Men of the ruling family, elders, witnesses, and attendants gathered in solemn expectation.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

She possessed the rare mind that
understood a palace was not only a
place of family, but of decisions.

AISHA sits veiled, composed, beside her WALI.

SHEIKH ISA sits opposite her, formal, still, separated by custom and ceremony. Between them, the QADI presides.

Nearby, SHEIKHA HAYA watches. Her face is calm.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

In time, her voice would carry weight
beyond the women's courtyard. She
would be trusted for her judgement,
respected for her strength, for seeing
clearly what Bahrain would need to
survive change.

Haya watches Aisha with acceptance, but with the complicated knowledge that another woman has crossed a threshold into the life of her husband and the destiny of Bahrain.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Haya had kept my heart tied to what
must not be lost.

Isa and Aisha rise, still not touching. The gathered family begins to stir around them.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Aisha would help me see what had to be
built.

Aisha looks across the courtyard. Haya looks back. Two women. One household. One country changing shape around them.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
And Bahrain, like any house asked
to endure, would need both memory
and mind.

82 INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / STUDY - DAY

82

A map of Bahrain lies open on Isa's desk.

HOLMES, 50s, broad-shouldered - a man who has argued with the
earth all his life, stands before SHEIKH ISA and SHEIKHA AISHA.
He has a perplexed look on his face.

SHEIKHA AISHA
Mr Holmes, you may be wondering why we
sent for you.

HOLMES
I presume it is to help find a
reliable water supply for Bahrain.
As I did for the Saudis?

Holmes looks to the map, already thinking as an engineer.

HOLMES (CONT'D)
It is difficult work, but not
impossible.

Aisha glances to Isa.

SHEIKHA AISHA
We did not ask you here only for
water.

Holmes looks up. Isa studies him carefully.

SHEIKH ISA
Oil, Mr Holmes.

HOLMES
Oil.

SHEIKH ISA
Yes.

HOLMES
Your Honour, many surveys have been
done. British geologists repeatedly
say there is no evidence of oil in
Bahrain.

SHEIKH ISA
But there is. I'm certain of it.

HOLMES

I don't see how you can be.

SHEIKH ISA

I have faith, Mr Holmes. In my father's dream.

HOLMES

Faith is not enough to convince an exploration company. The venture would be nothing more than a gamble.

Isa moves to the window. Looks out over the town.

SHEIKH ISA

My father believed Bahrain carried blessings beneath what men could see. The Tree of Life grows where nothing should grow. The sea gives us fresh water beneath salt. Why should the land be less generous than the sea?

Isa turns back.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

We have lived by pearl and tide. But tides change. A country must listen for what comes next. I believe Bahrain has not yet finished speaking.

Holmes looks from Isa to Aisha. Aisha's expression is steady. She is not indulging a dream; she is measuring a future.

SHEIKHA AISHA

If water is found, our people benefit.

HOLMES

And if oil is not found?

SHEIKHA ISA

Then we will still have asked the earth an important question.

Holmes is silent a moment. Then he taps a finger lightly against one marked point on the map.

HOLMES

A venture like this would require enormous resources.

SHEIKHA AISHA

That is where you come in, Mr Holmes.

HOLMES

Hmm. And every gamble needs someone foolish enough to take it on.

Holmes almost smiles.

HOLMES (CONT'D)

I suppose that is where I come in too?

Aisha has the smallest smile.

Holmes looks again at the map. The old hunger to test the impossible is already awake in him.

83 **INT. BUCKINGHAM PALACE / STUDY - DAY**

83

VICTORIA, older now, sits in a wheelchair by the fire, wrapped in a blanket against the cold. BROWN stands nearby with a dossier, reading from a telegram.

BROWN

"...I extend my profound gratitude to Your Majesty for the removal of Colonel Ross from Bahrain."

QUEEN VICTORIA

Ross has been removed?

BROWN

Yes, Ma'am. Our man Daly made the complaint.

QUEEN VICTORIA

I see. There must've been good reason then. Go on.

BROWN

(continues reading)

"His departure has already eased the path between our two great countries, and I trust his successor will understand that friendship is best served when it does not walk in only one direction."

QUEEN VICTORIA

The Sheikh has not lost his touch.

BROWN

No, Ma'am.

(he reads on)

(MORE)

BROWN (CONT'D)

"On another matter, as a hospital is now being constructed for the benefit of my people, I would be grateful if Your Majesty might lend assistance to our American friends, who have shown admirable willingness in the matter."

The Queen frowns slightly.

QUEEN VICTORIA

Americans?

BROWN

Yes, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

Americans are helping?

BROWN

Apparently, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

What, precisely, are they helping with?

BROWN

Building a hospital, Ma'am. Though they are doctors. I believe assistance is required for the building part.

QUEEN VICTORIA

I see. Continue.

BROWN

"Finally, I extend my profound thanks for the loan of the warship last month. It proved most useful in removing the pirate threat from our waters."

QUEEN VICTORIA

The loan of the what?

BROWN

(hesitates)

The warship, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

I do not know anything about a warship.

BROWN

No, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

Was there a warship?

BROWN

It appears there was, Ma'am.

QUEEN VICTORIA

And why was there a warship?

BROWN

It is how he dealt with the pirate threat, Ma'am.

The Queen absorbs this.

QUEEN VICTORIA

He borrows ships, recruits Americans, removes pirates, and complains of our officers with more elegance than most ministers manage in praise of them.

BROWN

Yes, Ma'am.

(a beat)

We have not yet replaced Ross. Whom shall we send?

QUEEN VICTORIA

Preferably someone better. And for goodness sake, send some hospital builders. Before Sheikh Isa decides to rebuild the entire Empire by himself.

Brown bows and heads for the door.

84 **EXT. PORT MANAMA - DAY**

84

A SERIES OF TIME CUTS:

The port expands before us. More warehouses. More cranes. More cargo. More noise. Steam. Shouting. Donkeys. Sailors. Pearl traders. Customs men. Bahrain growing in every direction at once.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Queen Victoria was good to her word.

SHEIKH ISA (52) stands on the dock with SHEIKH HAMAD (25).

DALY waits with them, stiff, watchful, already too comfortable in the heat. A steamer eases into port.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
Help was sent for the hospital.
Perhaps the presence of the Americans
encouraged the British to do more than
they might otherwise have done.

The gangplank lowers. Passengers disembark. A rotund British official steps onto the quay: GASKIN (60s), the new Political Agent. Daly makes the introduction. GASKIN barely waits.

GASKIN
Your Honour, will you reconsider our
proposal to assume collection and
supervision of custom duties?

Isa looks at him.

SHEIKH ISA
I will not.

Gaskin blinks. Isa holds his gaze.

TIME CUT:

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
Years passed. Many British officers
continued to come to Bahrain. Then
left. Like leaves on the wind.

SHEIKH ISA (55) stands on the dock with SHEIKH HAMAD (28). Daly, older, more decorated. Another steamer. Another gangplank.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
Each one claiming to understand us.
Each one needing to be taught again.

Daly next introduces: PRIDEAUX (40s) precise and self-satisfied.

PRIDEAUX
We will provide all necessary security
to prevent misdeeds. But we ask that
you cede authority in such matters.

SHEIKH ISA
I will not.

Prideaux's face sours. Daly watches, silent, measuring.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
No sooner did we become accustomed to
one than another replaced him.

TIME CUT:

The port is larger now. Busier. The Union Jack snaps above the British offices. Dhows crowd the harbour beneath it. Trade, labour, movement, the noise of a country alive with purpose.

SHEIKH ISA (65) stands on the dock with SHEIKH HAMAD (38)

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Daly remained the one constant. A man
I trusted very little – though never
with enough proof to do anything
useful about it.

Daly stands nearby. More lined. More decorated. More well-fed.
More decadent. Part of the furniture of empire now.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

And when the Queen was gone, so too
was the rare understanding she had
offered. Still they came. Ineffectual,
sometimes corrupt, and rarely any
better than the last.

Another steamer arrives. But this time, something feels different.

A tall Englishman steps onto the quay: JOHN GORDON LORIMER (43).
Hat, plain suit, two modest suitcases.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Until, a man stepped upon our shore
who was somehow – different.

Lorimer takes in the heat, the harbour, the crowded life of
Manama. Not dismissive. Attentive.

Daly sees it. Does not like it. He forces a smile.

DALY

Your Honour. May I present Mr. John
Gordon Lorimer, the new Political
Resident.

Lorimer bows respectfully.

LORIMER

Sheikh Isa. A great honour.

SHEIKH ISA

Mr. Lorimer. Welcome to Bahrain.

WIDE ON THE PORT – in full motion. Steamers, dhows, warehouses,
cranes, traders, sailors, the whole machinery of a changing
Bahrain.

As the men make their way towards the town.

SUPER: PORT MANAMA - 1913

85 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / DINING ROOM - DAY**

85

The men at a dining table have lunch. LORIMER sits opposite ISA & HAMAD. DALY is by Lorimer's side.

LORIMER

I was pleased to learn the Victoria Memorial Hospital has opened its doors.

SHEIKH ISA

The Queen gave her word in this life. She is honoured in the next.

DALY

The Americans take pride in building their hospital first. American's for you.

Lorimer ignores him - looks back to Isa.

LORIMER

The Queen was a generous monarch. I am certain you shall find His Highness equally so.

SHEIKH ISA

Thank you, Mr Lorimer. Through you, it has been made clear.

Lorimer accepts the compliment.

DALY

And what of the new tariffs, Mr Lorimer?

LORIMER

There will be no new tariffs. I have already been instructed they should be returned to what they were.

Isa nods, pleased but careful not to show too much.

DALY

By whose order?

LORIMER

It comes from a very high place, Captain Daly.

DALY

(he stiffens)

Major Daly, I'll thank you. It has
been some time since I was a captain.

LORIMER

Apologies, Major. I stand corrected.

Sheikh Hamad lowers his eyes, hiding the faintest smile.

Daly wipes his mouth, suddenly done with the conversation.

DALY

If you'll excuse me, I've rather
pressing duties.

(he rises)

With respect, as always, Your Honour.

A short bow to Isa and Hamad, a chilly nod to Lorimer, then exits.
The door closes. Lorimer watches it a moment - as does Hamad.

SHEIKH HAMAD

Duties? Hmmph.

SHEIKH ISA

Hamad.

LORIMER

I may have only been here an hour, but
I have already established that Major
Daly has mastered the art of walking
between raindrops without getting wet.

Lorimer is enjoying himself.

SHEIKH ISA

You are unusually candid for a man
sent by the British Government.

LORIMER

(quoting)

"A man must ask East and West to
meet without forcing either to
kneel."

SHEIKH ISA

Rihani.

LORIMER

He believes the Arab world can be free
and still remain itself.

SHEIKH ISA

You have studied our scholars words.

LORIMER

I have begun to learn their weight,
Your Honour. In time, I hope to learn
how best I may serve Bahrain's future.

Isa studies him. Something like trust begins.

SHEIKH ISA

Then allow me to show you how we are
starting to build it.

86 **EXT. VICTORIA MEMORIAL HOSPITAL - DAY**

86

The newly opened hospital stands in the heat. Nurses attend to
PATIENTS beneath the shaded entrance.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

And in the weeks that followed, I
did show him.

ISA, HAMAD, LORIMER & DALY, along with a contingent of important
sheikhs are greeted by an American missionary, his wife, and
husband and wife doctors.

SHEIKH ISA

Mr. Lorimer, may I introduce Dr. Thoms
and Dr. Wells. Reverend Samuel Zwemer,
and Mrs. Zwemer.

Lorimer shakes their hands.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Mr. Lorimer is the new Political
Resident.

LORIMER

It is a great pleasure.

87 **INT. VICTORIA MEMORIAL HOSPITAL - LATER**

87

Isa & Lorimer walk the ward. Nurses move between patients resting
in clean beds. A child is examined nearby.

Across the ward, Daly holds court with the Americans, laughing
like an old friend.

LORIMER

I thought Daly did not approve of the
American presence.

SHEIKH ISA

He doesn't. Nor my willingness to make
alliance so... public.

They glance across to Daly, all smiles and cordiality.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I respect the American's "can-do"
spirit. I think that's what they call
it. Even in a British hospital.

LORIMER

He seems very cordial with them.

SHEIKH ISA

Raindrops, Mr. Lorimer.

Lorimer smiles at their private joke.

88 **EXT./INT. KHADIJA AL KOBRA SCHOOL / CONSTRUCTION SITE - DAY** 88

A school under construction. Fresh painted walls. Builders work on
the interior. Isa enters with Hamad, Lorimer, and Daly.

SHEIKH ISA

The first of many, Insha'Allah.

DALY

A fine school to instruct the young
men of Bahrain.

SHEIKHA AISHA

Actually, this school is for the
women.

They turn. SHEIKHA AISHA steps forward, composed, authoritative.
Isa introduces her with quiet pride.

SHEIKH ISA

My wife, Sheikha Aisha. The school
program is her responsibility.

Lorimer bows respectfully.

SHEIKHA AISHA

Mr. Lorimer.

LORIMER

Most impressive, Sheikha. Many schools
in Britain are not as well appointed.

SHEIKHA AISHA
Peace. Justice. Healthcare.
Education for all. These are the
cornerstones of any society that
wishes to endure.

SHEIKH ISA
And of course we shall require a
reliable fresh water supply.

89 **EXT. EXPLORATORY WELL - DESERT - DAY**

89

DRILLING RIGS stand against the horizon – timber and metal
derricks clank in the heat. Workers haul pipes. Camels wait beside
stacked equipment.

ISA, HAMAD, LORIMER, & DALY are joined by HOLMES, dust-beaten.

LORIMER
But these are oil derricks.

SHEIKH ISA
Yes. Oil. And also water. Most
efficient.

DALY
Mr Holmes here works for Eastern
and General.

HOLMES
The company have a prospecting and
mining concession. Two years, with
an option to extend.

SHEIKH ISA
At their cost and risk. And while they
search for oil, they also drill for
water.

HAMAD
Bahrain needs fresh water more than
promises.

Lorimer looks to Isa.

LORIMER
A shrewd business proposition, Your
Honour. If I might say. Mr Holmes
you think you'll succeed?

HOLMES

So far, in a year of trying, I've found nothing but sand, salt, and rock.

He glances at the derricks.

LORIMER

Yet you continue?

HOLMES

The world is beginning to pay handsomely for oil. That is why the company carries the risk.

(looks to Isa)

Though I confess there are days I fear it may be hopeless, Your Honour.

Isa smiles wryly.

SHEIKH ISA

Fear is permitted, Mr Holmes.
Surrender is not.

90 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY /LORIMER'S OFFICE - DAY**

90

- MONTAGE BEGINS -

LORIMER pores over accounts, ledgers, concession papers, shipping records. Columns of figures. Marginal notes. Names circled. Questions underlined.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Mr Lorimer wasted little time
proving his friendship to Bahrain.

Lorimer stops at one clause. Reads it again. His pencil marks the page.

91 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY/ DALY'S OFFICE - EVENING**

91

The King's portrait watches over DALY, seated behind his desk, comfortable in his authority.

Lorimer stands before him with a file of documents.

LORIMER

I've been reviewing the Eastern and
General concession.

Lorimer places the file on Daly's desk.

LORIMER (CONT'D)

I have some questions.

Daly's smile remains. Only his eyes change.

92 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / BOARDROOM - DAY**

92

Lorimer argues with BRITISH ACCOUNTANTS over stacked ledgers. One accountant points to a column. Another shakes his head.

Lorimer does not yield.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

He spent months inside the machinery of British affairs, learning how one word in an agreement could move more wealth than a fleet of ships.

Lorimer copies figures from one ledger into his notebook. He compares signatures. Something does not balance.

93 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / DALY'S OFFICE - DAY**

93

Another day. Another file.

LORIMER

The terms state that if fresh water is not found, Sheikh Isa pays a penalty for each unsuccessful well.

DALY

Correct.

LORIMER

Terms most unfavourable to Sheikh Isa.

DALY

Bahrain requires water. Eastern and General require incentive. Such arrangements are rarely poetic.

94 **EXT. OIL FIELD - DAY**

94

Heat shimmers over the rigs. Lorimer follows HOLMES through the drilling site, notebook in hand. Holmes is too busy to stop.

LORIMER

How many wells failed?

HOLMES

Too many.

LORIMER

And how much is the penalty?

Holmes stops just long enough to look at him.

HOLMES

Penalty? What penalty?

95 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / LORIMER'S OFFICE - NIGHT**

95

A lamp burns low. Lorimer lays several documents side by side. The concession. The water clause. Company correspondence. A schedule of payments.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

His enquiries turned from months into an entire year. Yet he kept returning to the same troubling question.

He draws a line from one clause to another. Then stops at a reference typed in passing: "AS PER SIDE LETTER."

96 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / DALY'S OFFICE - DAY**

96

Lorimer stands before Daly again.

LORIMER

What if Holmes finds oil?

DALY

If oil is found, profits naturally flow to the company. They carry the risk.

LORIMER

And Bahrain carries the penalties.

DALY

Bahrain receives what was agreed.

Lorimer holds up a document.

LORIMER

This refers to a side letter. I have not been able to find it.

DALY

I know of no side letter.

LORIMER

Then I shall need to look harder.
Thank you for now, Major.

Lorimer gathers the documents. He turns for the door.

Daly remains behind his desk, staring at the closing door.

For the first time, fear in his eyes.

97 **EXT. LORIMER RESIDENCE - NIGHT**

97

Lorimer's house stands in shadow. Shutters half-open. Lamps guttering in the humid air.

ISA & HAMAD arrive on horseback. They rein in hard.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

But as quickly as Mr Lorimer made
friends, he perhaps also cemented
enemies.

Two BRITISH OFFICERS stand outside the entrance. Nearby, a horse-drawn ambulance carriage waits, its rear flaps open.

Isa and Hamad dismount.

OFFICER #1

We notified the palace as soon as
we found out, Your Honour.

Isa pushes past the officers and enters. Hamad follows.

98 **INT. LORIMER RESIDENCE - STUDY - CONTINUOUS**

98

Ambulance attendants lift Lorimer's body onto a stretcher, mercifully drawing a sheet over the bloodied head. A rifle lies on the floor near the window. Blood marks the wall behind the desk.

Isa takes in every detail.

SHEIKH ISA

Who found him?

Two frightened MALE SERVANTS to one side. They bow deeply.

SERVANT

I did, Your Honour.
(voice trembles)
I came when I heard the shot. I could
do nothing.

The officers enter behind them.

OFFICER #1

Major Daly has placed the matter under
British investigation, Your Honour.

Isa's eyes remain on the covered body.

OFFICER #2

It appears Mr Lorimer was cleaning
his weapon and it misfired.

Isa looks now to the weapon on the floor.

SHEIKH ISA

Mr Lorimer was not a careless man.

99 **EXT. LORIMER RESIDENCE - CONTINUOUS**

99

Isa and Hamad watch as Lorimer's body is placed into the
ambulance. It has started to rain.

SHEIKH HAMAD

What is to be done now, Father?

Isa does not answer, his thoughts in a torrent.

A crack of lighting. Thunder.

SHEIKH ISA

Come, Hamad. A storm is coming.

More thunder rolls over Bahrain as father and son ride away.

100 **EXT. TOOBLI BAY - DAWN**

100

The fleet is far from shore. The wind has risen. Dark weather
builds fast. A DHOW CAPTAIN looks to the horizon.

DHOW CAPTAIN

Raise sail! Now!

Sailors scramble.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

The storm arrived. Lorimer's death.
and then before anything could be done
to address it -

Across the fleet, men secure baskets, ropes, batten what they can.

Fear moves from face to face.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
The storm to end all storms.

101 **EXT. MANAMA STREETS - MORNING**

101

The storm has made landfall. Isa rides through the rising chaos.

SHEIKH ISA
Take shelter! To high ground!

Isa's men move street by street, helping residents indoors.

Doors slam. Shutters close. Stalls are abandoned. The wind builds with frightening speed. People run for shelter.

102 **INT./EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / VARIOUS - CONTINUOUS**

102

SHEIKHA AISHA and the household staff batten doors and windows.

CITIZENS plead for shelter at the palace entrance.

SHEIKHA AISHA
Let them in.

The doors open. Families rush inside, soaked and terrified.

Zalaikha looks out through a window, frightened.

The storm howls. Palm trees bend sideways. Attendants and guards fight for cover. Rain lashes Ahmed's tree.

HAYA on a balcony. Rain lashes her. She grips the stone wall, helpless before the scale of it. She looks out over the town -

Below, Manama is being torn apart - roofs lifting, palms bending, people running through flooded lanes.

103 **EXT. OPEN SEA / PEARL DIVING FLEET - EVENING**

103

Day has turned to night. Dhows pitches violently. Divers huddle on deck. The captain shouts, but the wind devours his words.

Lightning tears open the sky. Massive waves threaten the dhows.

Men panic and scramble. Dhows rock and collide. Sails snap loose.

Brave pearl divers stare terrified at the churning water. And are thrown overboard. Timbers split. Pearls spill into the angry sea.

104 **EXT. MANAMA SHORE - NIGHT**

104

The storm arrives with full fury.

Homes buckle. Palm trees tear loose. People scramble from collapsing walls and flying debris.

105 **EXT. MANAMA STREETS - CONTINUOUS**

105

Wind screams through flooded streets. Rain lashes sideways.

Branches, roof tiles, baskets, doors – everything not fixed becomes a weapon.

Isa rides through the flood on horseback, cloak whipped wild behind him, half-blind in the rain.

SHEIKH ISA
To high ground! Go!

A YOUNG MOTHER staggers into his path with one child clutched in her arms. She is soaked, wild with terror.

YOUNG MOTHER
My boy!

Isa reins in hard.

YOUNG MOTHER (CONT'D)
Help him! Please! My boy!

She points back toward a half-collapsed house.

106 **EXT. COLLAPSED HOUSE FRONT - CONTINUOUS**

106

Isa pushes through the storm toward the damaged house.

A BOY of eight lies pinned, a heavy WOODEN BEAM across his legs. Water surges around him. He's going to drown.

Isa starts forward. Then stops himself.

For one suspended beat, the storm falls away.

Isa studies the wreckage.

The beam pins the boy. The broken house-front leans dangerously.

The flood pushes hard from the left, forcing debris toward them. To the right, a narrow strip of raised stone still holds.

HAMAD (O.S.)

Father!

HAMAD forces his way through the storm. Hamad sees it at once.

HAMAD (CONT'D)

Not from the front. The wall will come
down.

Isa moves along the raised stone to the boy's side, dropping into the water beside him.

Hamad takes position on the opposite side of the beam, bracing his feet against the current.

SHEIKH ISA

When I pull him clear, you take the
weight.

Floodwater surges through the street. The boy goes under.

The damaged wall GROANS. The beam shifts an inch.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Now!

Together they lift. The beam rises just enough.

Hamad takes the full weight, straining, nearly driven to one knee.

Isa pulls the boy's legs free and hauls him into his arms.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Go!

Hamad lets the beam drop and throws himself clear.

The timber crashes down.

The wall collapses into the flood behind them.

Isa carries the boy to his mother. She clutches him, stunned,
weeping, unable to speak.

Isa turns toward the storm, already searching for the next cry.

Hamad catches his arm. Rain streams down Hamad's face. His eyes
are steady. Clear.

Father and son turn together. And disappear back into the storm

107 **EXT. MANAMA / VARIOUS - MORNING**

107

On horseback, SHEIKH ISA moves through what remains of his world.

Fragments of boats. Fishing nets. Palm fronds. The lifeblood of the community reduced to wreckage.

Farmers and pearl divers alike stand among ruined livelihoods. Boats lie splintered in the streets. Palm trunks torn from the earth. Whole walls peeled open to the sky.

Men and women sift through the remains of their lives with stunned, exhausted hands.

Isa rides on. He passes HAMAD, who oversees men distributing provisions to citizens in need.

Isa nods to his son with approval.

Nearby, NURSES help the wounded. RABBI JOSEF and members of his synagogue hand out blankets. SHEIKHA HAYA and her female servants beckon women to join in prayer.

Isa nods to her. She holds his gaze a moment.

108 **EXT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD GARDEN - CONTINUOUS**

108

Ahmed's Frangipani Tree is being righted by the palace staff.

109 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / RAMPARTS - DAWN**

109

HAMAD looks over the devastated town.

Roofs torn off. Streets choked with mud and wreckage.

ISA joins him. For a moment, father and son say nothing.

HAMAD

Nearly five thousand lives, Father.

(beat)

The fleet is gone. Ships, crews, the season's harvest. The whole coast has been broken.

Isa absorbs the scale of it.

SHEIKH ISA

Then we begin with the living.

Hamad turns to him.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Food. Shelter. Medicine. Whatever can be saved, we save. Whatever must be rebuilt, we rebuild.

SHEIKH HAMAD

Yes, Father.

Isa reaches beneath his cloak and withdraws a long object wrapped carefully in cloth.

SHEIKH ISA

There is something I must give you.

Hamad takes it. He unwraps the cloth.

SHEIKH ALI'S SWORD.

Hamad looks at his father, unable to speak.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

My father's sword is now yours.

Hamad grips it carefully, reverently.

SHEIKH HAMAD

Father... I am not ready for such an honour.

Isa almost smiles.

SHEIKH ISA

That is what I once thought too.

He looks back over the ruined town.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

My father taught me not to rush into danger. In the storm, I did not have to remember that lesson alone.

Isa lays a hand on the sword.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I carried this through war and peace. Triumph and loss. None of those gave it value except service to others. A reminder to build beyond ourselves.

Hamad's eyes fill.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

All my life I have told Bahrain it has a future.

(MORE)

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Now I place that future in your hands
freeing it from uncertainty.

Isa turns fully towards Hamad.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

The British propose to make
decisions with or without my
approval.

A brief shadow crosses him.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

If they will not allow a ruler his
authority then we shall give them
two rulers instead -

Hamad stands proudly, already sensing what is to come.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I shall name you as my successor. In
the majlis, to our people and to the
British. For Bahrain's future.

SHEIKH HAMAD

I don't know if I deserve such an
honour.

Isa places a hand upon his shoulder.

SHEIKH ISA

Come. Let us give Bahrain
certainty.

Hamad holds the sword to his chest. Father and son embrace.

110 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / STUDY - DAY**

110

ISA stands at his desk, reading a letter. HOLMES waits before
him, uneasy.

HOLMES

I am truly sorry, Your Honour.
Lorimer was a good man.

Isa does not look up.

HOLMES (CONT'D)

He asked me to retrieve this side
letter from the company office. It
only just arrived.

Isa reads the page again.

SHEIKH ISA

A private commission attached to
the concession. To Daly.

HOLMES

Yes, Your Honour.

(a beat)

The formal papers are clean. The
interest was concealed outside
them.

SHEIKH ISA

So the agreement presented to
Bahrain was not the agreement being
made.

HOLMES

Not entirely.

Isa folds the letter with controlled care.

SHEIKH ISA

Daly stood between my country and
the company, then took payment from
the passage.

HOLMES

Seemingly he would profit. Whether
from oil. Or from penalties.

(beat)

I'm afraid I had something more to
tell you, Your Honour. Eastern and
General have ordered me to cease
operations.

SHEIKH ISA

I do not understand.

HOLMES

They say it is too expensive to
rebuild. Too difficult to continue.
They have instructed me to pursue
ventures elsewhere.

SHEIKH ISA

Where will they send you?

HOLMES

Anywhere but Bahrain.

(beat)

I am sorry, Your Honour. Bahrain
has touched my soul. I shall miss
it terribly.

Isa sighs with profound disappointment.

SHEIKH ISA
And Bahrain shall miss you, Mr
Holmes.

111 **EXT. TREE OF LIFE - DUSK**

111

Sheikh Isa leads his horse across the sand towards the TREE OF LIFE. Miraculously still standing after the storm.

Isa stops before it. He lays a hand on the bark, as though taking counsel from something older than time.

Isa's eyes fill. He wipes them with the palms of his hands.

SHEIKH ISA
Father...
(beat)
I have searched all my life. To
understand your dream.

He looks up into the branches, then kneels in the sand, raising his hands in prayer.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
O Allah... with hardship comes ease.
Guide me to what is good for me, for
my faith, for my life, and for
Bahrain, then ordain it for me, ease
it for me, and bless it for me.

The wind stirs through the tree.

Isa lowers his hands.

Drained, he settles against the roots, prayer beads still in his hand. His eyes close.

Above him, a shooting star cuts across the sky and vanishes.

112 **EXT. DESERT / TREE OF LIFE - NIGHT - DREAM**

112

Isa opens his eyes.

A WHITE DEER stands before him. Pale. Luminous. Impossible.

It watches him.

Then turns and moves into the desert.

Isa rises and follows.

The deer crosses the dunes with strange grace, drawing him toward the dark outline of the MOUNTAIN OF SMOKE.

At a ridge, it stops before a single OIL DERRICK.

As Isa approaches -

The MASKED MAN erupts from the sand before him.

Blade drawn.

He cuts the deer down.

Isa reaches for his sword. The scabbard is empty.

The Masked Man advances.

Isa charges, tackles him into the sand, and tears away the mask.

Beneath it -

YOUNG ISA.

Bloodied. Terrified. Bearing the wounds of the battlefield where Sheikh Ali died. His eyes are full of pain and guilt.

YOUNG ISA
It was not my fault.
(a beat)
I did not want Father to die.

Isa stares at his younger self. The years collapse between them. At last, Isa begins to weep.

SHEIKH ISA
I forgive you.

Young Isa is overcome with relief. A burden has been lifted.

Isa helps Young Isa to his feet. For a moment, they stand together in the desert.

Then Young Isa turns and walks away into the dawn light.

113 **EXT. TREE OF LIFE - DAWN**

113

Isa wakes beneath the tree. The prayer beads still in his hand. First light touches the bark above him.

He sits up slowly, looks to the heavens. Something he has carried for years has finally shown him its face.

SHEIKH ISA
Alhamdulillah.
(a whisper)
Praise be to God.

He goes to his horse, climbs onto the saddle and rides off.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
That morning, I awoke at peace with
the boy I had been.

114 **EXT. SHORELINE - MORNING**

114

A DATE FARMER pulls a DEAD CHILD from the water.

A YOUNG GIRL, MARYAM, six, sits in the sand, crying out to sea for her father. He has not returned.

SHEIKHA AISHA appears and gathers the girl into her arms. A frantic MOTHER runs toward them.

MOTHER
Maryam! I thought I'd lost you!

Aisha hands the child to her. The mother clutches Maryam, overwhelmed with gratitude and grief.

Aisha moves on, shaken, walking along the ruined shore.

She stops at a boat that lies half-buried in the sand.

Aisha touches the hull. Her fingers come away stained with BLACK RESIDUE.

115 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / COURTYARD - DAY**

115

AISHA hurries forward as ISA rides into the courtyard.

SHEIKHA AISHA
I waited for your return.

Isa dismounts as the horse is lead away by attendents.

SHEIKHA AISHA (CONT'D)
I found something this morning. A
blessing among the ruins.

Isa steps toward her.

SHEIKHA AISHA (CONT'D)
Liquid bitumen. On the hull of a
beached pearling boat.

SHEIKH ISA
Bitumen?

SHEIKHA AISHA
Tar in the sea can be a sign.

SHEIKH ISA
Or debris carried by the storm.

Isa looks toward the damaged courtyard, the torn palms.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
The storm brought half the Gulf to our shore.

Aisha watches him closely.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
There is no oil in Bahrain. It was only a dream.

Isa stops. Realises what he's just said.

SHEIKHA AISHA
A dream. Do you truly believe that?

Once again, Isa cannot answer.

116 **EXT. MOUNTAIN OF SMOKE / OIL FIELDS - DAY**

116

The storm has torn through the oil field. Derricks lean broken. Debris lies in the sand. Ripped canvas snaps in the wind.

SHEIKH ISA rides in, reins in hard.

SHEIKH ISA
(shouts over the wind)
Where is Holmes?

Workers salvage what they can.

WORKER
He's left for the port, Your Honour.

117 **EXT. PORT MANAMA - DAY**

117

The port is wounded by the storm. Broken crates. Torn sailcloth. Men repair what they can.

HOLMES waits near the quay with his luggage. But there is no ship. He stares out at the empty water.

Sheikh Isa rides up, dismounts, and walks toward him.

SHEIKH ISA
You are leaving so soon?

HOLMES
I would be, Your Honour, if there
were a ship.

He glances back to the harbour.

SHEIKH ISA
Mr Holmes, what if tar was found in
the water?

HOLMES
You found tar?

SHEIKH ISA
Aisha did. Could the storm have
carried it here?

Holmes does not answer for a moment.

HOLMES
It is extremely unlikely.

SHEIKH ISA
And what would be more likely?

HOLMES
A local deposit. Disturbed by the
storm.

SHEIKH ISA
You never stopped believing there
was oil here.

HOLMES
What does it matter?
(a bitter smile)
All I have are empty wells, broken
equipment, and orders to leave.

SHEIKH ISA
I want the concession returned to
me.

HOLMES
Your Honour... to what purpose?

Isa steps closer.

SHEIKH ISA
Faith, Mr Holmes. Remember?

Holmes holds his gaze.

HOLMES
Even if I could help recover the concession, it would come at a steep price. They will expect you to honour what Daly arranged.

Isa's eyes do not waver.

SHEIKH ISA
We needn't be concerned about Daly.

118 **INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / DALY'S OFFICE - DAY**

118

The office bears the scars of the storm. A broken shutter. Damp papers. Sand and rain blown across the floor. Servants have already cleared the worst of it, but DALY is tidying what remains himself with clipped irritation.

He lifts two duelling swords from his desk, wipes moisture from one with a cloth, and returns it to a polished cabinet.

Before Daly can answer, the door opens. SHEIKH ISA enters. Daly turns, surprised. Then quickly recovers his official smile.

DALY
Your Honour. I was not told to expect you.

SHEIKH ISA
Then I apologise for the discourtesy.

DALY
Not at all. Storms leave everyone entering by unexpected doors.

Isa glances at the damaged room.

SHEIKH ISA
The storm has been unkind. To all of Bahrain.

DALY
A terrible loss.

He returns the first sword to the cabinet and lifts the second.

SHEIKH ISA
You fence, Major Daly?

DALY
A little.

He tests the blade's weight.

DALY (CONT'D)
Badly enough to remember the
bruises. Well enough to inflict a
few.
(beat)
Your Honour, I assume you are not
only here to admire my collection?

SHEIKH ISA
No. I came to speak of Mr Lorimer.
(beat)
They say in a duel a weapon teaches
truth quickly.

DALY
That it does.

SHEIKH ISA
Shall we see what truth it teaches
this morning?

Daly takes the second sword from the cabinet - offers it to Isa.

DALY
A friendly exercise, of course.

Isa holds his gaze a moment. Then accepts the sword.

SHEIKH ISA
Of course.

They take position. Steel touches steel.

DALY
You keep the hand low.

SHEIKH ISA
It invites confidence.

DALY
Or carelessness.

SHEIKH ISA
Only in a careless man.

Daly presses. Isa turns the blade aside with casual precision.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Mr Lorimer was not such a man.

DALY

An unfortunate accident.

SHEIKH ISA

Or a convenient one.

Isa circles him. Daly's smile thins.

DALY

Careful. A friendly exercise can turn.

SHEIKH ISA

Only when one man forgets it is friendly.

Daly attacks a little harder.

DALY

You are always friendly, Sheikh Isa. Always patient. Courteous.

SHEIKH ISA

You mistake courtesy for obedience.

The duel sharpens. Daly is competent, but angry. Isa remains calm, economical, exact.

DALY

We've protected these islands for decades. We help govern properly.

SHEIKH ISA

On your terms.

DALY

On terms that preserve British authority. Treaty continuity legitimises our presence here. That is not merely privilege. It is responsibility.

SHEIKH ISA

And personal profit? What part does that play?

Daly strikes harder.

DALY

I would be very cautious with such a claim.

Daly lunges. Isa turns the blade aside, steps in with sudden force, and cuts the air to either side of Daly's head.

Daly freezes.

Isa flicks his wrist. Daly's sword flies from his hand and skids across the damp floor. Isa's blade rises to Daly's throat. Daly backs into his chair by the desk and drops into it.

SHEIKH ISA

You mistake restraint for weakness.

Daly breathes hard. Isa lowers the sword. Reaches into his robe and removes the side letter. Places it on Daly's desk.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

I think you know its contents.

Daly stares at it. His face drains.

DALY

This proves nothing.

SHEIKH ISA

The Crown may choose to determine that.

The door opens. SHEIKH HAMAD enters with two BRITISH OFFICERS carrying pistols.

For the first time, Daly has no words.

119 INT. THE BRITISH AGENCY / BOARDROOM ROOM - DAY

119

A TEAM OF LAWYERS from the Eastern and General Syndicate sit before SHEIKH ISA and SHEIKH HAMAD. HOLMES stands beside them.

Isa nods, and Hamad hands the senior LAWYER a deed of payment.

SHEIKH HAMAD

The agreed amount.

The lawyer inspects it, satisfied, then signs.

LAWYER

Fair enough. Not what we lost, but enough to be rid of it.

He gathers the documents.

LAWYER (CONT'D)

Frankly, Your Honour, I doubt anyone will bother looking here again.

(MORE)

LAWYER (CONT'D)

There is no oil in the Arabian Gulf.
We have the financial deficit to prove
it.

The lawyers rise, shake hands all round, and exit.

Holmes watches them go, holding his tongue.

SHEIKH HAMAD

We paid them three times what they
paid you.

HOLMES

I'm sorry, Your Honour. I warned they
were ruthless men.

Hamad looks to Holmes.

SHEIKH HAMAD

And we must raise the cost to rebuild
the wells.

SHEIKH ISA

It is a larger cost to sell our
future.

He looks down at a map on the table.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Schools. Canals. Medicines. Roads.
Every promise we have made would begin
waiting on British support again.

Isa places his hand over Bahrain.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

My father did not want Bahrain merely
improved. He wanted her free. A
country cannot call itself sovereign
while another man owns what lies
beneath its feet.

Hamad sees the spark in his father's eyes.

HOLMES

We'll start drilling tomorrow.

SHEIKH ISA

One more well. Another. Then another
and another. Until the land answers.

HOLMES

Of course, Your Honour.
(a smile tugs)
(MORE)

HOLMES (CONT'D)

Though I fear there'll be more days
ahead when it will seem hopeless.

Isa smiles wryly as well.

SHEIKH ISA

Fear is permitted, Mr Holmes.
Surrender is not.

Holmes smiles back. And paces to the door with renewed purpose.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

But the earth does not give up its
secrets because men are impatient.

120 **EXT. JABAL AL-DUKHAN - DESERT DRILL SITE - DAY**

120

A drill turns against a hard, white sky.

HOLMES stands beside the rig, face burned by sun and failure,
watching the cable hammer down into the earth.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

There were years when all we found was
dust.

The drill slows. Stops. A WORKER looks up from the bore hole.

WORKER

We hit rock again, Mr Holmes.

Holmes says nothing. Just stares at the dead well.

Holmes turns, ashamed - to Isa observing nearby.

SHEIKH ISA

You must ask again, Mr Holmes.

Holmes nods with determination.

HOLMES

Yes, Your Honour.

121 **EXT. ANOTHER DRILL SITE - ANOTHER DAY**

121

Men haul pipe. Sweat. Flies. Heat. The drill breaks through.

A violent surge of WATER erupts - but the men recoil. A worker
cups it. Tastes. Spits.

WORKER

More salt!

Holmes turns away, furious.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
And when the earth did speak,
sometimes it mocked us.

122 **EXT. WORKERS' CAMP - DAY**

122

Holmes storms through the camp, shouting at exhausted men.

HOLMES
Again! We drill again!

The workers are too tired to answer. One throws down a length of pipe. It crashes into the deck. Holmes spins on him.

HOLMES (CONT'D)
You want to go home? Then go! But do
not stand here and call yourself a
driller!

The man lowers his eyes. Holmes catches himself. His rage is really fear.

123 **EXT. ANOTHER DRILL SITE - NIGHT**

123

The brake wheel screams as a drill line runs too fast.

Men shout as a WORKER grabs the spinning handle and it smashes him aside.

Holmes lunges for the brake, wrestling it down, burning his hands. The whole rig shudders.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
There were injuries. Accidents. Days
when men cursed the work. Nights when
they thought morning wouldn't come.

124 **EXT. DRILL SITE - DAY**

124

Another bore hole. Another failure. Abandoned wells across the desert - crude timber scars against the stone.

Holmes stands, spent. With Isa again. The failed wells stretch before them like graves.

SHEIKH ISA
Ask again, Mr Holmes.

Holmes cannot quite meet Isa's eye.

HOLMES
Yes, Your Honour.

125 **EXT. PARIS - DAY**

125

An aerial view of Paris. Boulevards, bridges, the Seine, smoke rising from chimneys, motorcars and carriages move through the city's arteries.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
Then when hope was almost lost, we
were given reason to still believe.

In the distance - rapidly approaching - the Tour Eiffel.

SUPER: PARIS, SPRING - 1930

Move toward the structure, closer - through girders and platforms,
toward the first level -

126 **INT. EIFFEL TOWER RESTAURANT - FIRST PLATFORM - DAY**

126

Through the window - and toward -

JACQUES CARTIER sits alone at a table overlooking the city of light. A fine bottle of Bordeaux breathes beside him. A glass in his hand.

He is older, but with the same alert curiosity in his eyes. Paris belongs to him, yet his mind is elsewhere.

The MAÎTRE D' sweeps in with a WAITER behind him, carrying a silver-domed platter.

MAÎTRE D'
(In French, subtitled)
Monsieur Cartier. Your favourite.

Cartier turns, mildly brought back to the world.

The waiter places the platter before him. The maître d' lifts the silver cover.

A dozen plump oysters glisten on crushed ice.

MAÎTRE D' (CONT'D)
(In French, subtitled)
From the sweet waters of Bahrain.
Fresh from the morning's ship.

Cartier looks at the oysters. Bahrain. The word means much. He smiles.

CARTIER
(In French, subtitled)
Thank you.

The maître d' hovers, pleased with the theatre of it.

MAÎTRE D'
(In French, subtitled)
Much easier to obtain these days,
Monsieur.

Cartier gives the faintest smile, barely listening.

MAÎTRE D' (CONT'D)
(In French, subtitled)
And the new collection? My wife is
an avid connoisseur of your fine
work.

Cartier looks out through the window, across Paris.

CARTIER
(In French, subtitled)
Tell Madame she is generous.

The maître d' waits for more. Cartier offers none.

MAÎTRE D'
(In French, subtitled)
Bon appétit, Monsieur Cartier.

The maître d' bows. He and the waiter withdraw.

Cartier sips his wine then picks up the first oyster. A small
squeeze of lemon. He tips it into his mouth.

Almost at once, his expression changes.

Not pleasure. Irritation. He scowls, and brings a napkin to his
lips. He spits into the napkin. Looks down.

We do not see what rests within his hands. But Cartier does.

His annoyance vanishes. His face breaks into awe. He beholds the
wonder of wonders.

127 INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / STUDY - DAY

127

Sea light dapples the walls as SHEIKH ISA (72) awaits. Majeed
appears at the doorway.

MAJEED
Monsieur Cartier, Your Honour.

JACQUES CARTIER enters. Impeccably dressed despite the heat. The years between these two are full. Isa smiles.

SHEIKH ISA
Mr. Cartier.

CARTIER
Your Honour.

Cartier bows deeply. Isa steps forward and clasps both of Cartier's hands warmly.

SHEIKH ISA
You have taken your time returning to Bahrain.

CARTIER
I feared the sea might humiliate me again.

Isa laughs softly.

SHEIKH ISA
You survived last time.

CARTIER
Barely. Your divers made me feel like a church bell thrown into the ocean.

The old warmth returns between them. Isa gestures to seating.

SHEIKH ISA
Please.

They sit. A servant brings coffee and withdraws. For a moment, both men allow the silence.

CARTIER
I heard of your loss. Your son.

Isa's smile fades.

CARTIER (CONT'D)
I am very sorry.

Isa lowers his eyes.

SHEIKH ISA
A man learns that grief does not leave him. It only changes where it sits.

Cartier nods, moved by this.

CARTIER
Pratap spoke of you often.

SHEIKH ISA
You saw him?

CARTIER
In India. At the end.

Isa absorbs this carefully.

CARTIER (CONT'D)
He died in his home. Peacefully.
Surrounded by family – everything he
loved.

A small, sad smile from Isa.

CARTIER (CONT'D)
He was happy, Your Honour.

SHEIKH ISA
Allah is merciful.

CARTIER
He told me Bahrain had two kinds of
treasure. The pearls men sell. And the
people who make them worth selling.

SHEIKH ISA
That sounds like Pratap.

Cartier reaches into his coat and removes a small, exquisite box.
Gold, enamel, fine stones worked into its lid. Beautiful without
being vulgar. He places it on the table between them.

CARTIER
I came because I wished to return
something.

Cartier opens the box.

Inside rests a single BLACK PEARL.

Set elegantly on a simple gold chain. Not ostentatious. Perfect.

For a moment, Isa is a boy again, delighting in the impossible. He
says nothing as he reaches slowly into the box and lifts it.

The pearl catches the light, holding darkness and colour at once –
black, green, silver, the faintest blue. Darkness made luminous.

SHEIKH ISA
From Bahrain?

CARTIER

Yes.

(a beat)

It came to me over lunch. I almost choked on it. Destiny has a sense of humour.

Isa's eyes stay on the pearl.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

It crossed the sea to me. Now I return it to its true owner.

Isa looks up.

CARTIER (CONT'D)

You once told me to meet the sea that makes the pearls. I did. I have Bahrain to thank for my wealth. Since then, I have believed the sea remembers more than men do.

Isa holds the pearl, unable to look away.

SHEIKH ISA

I thought it was only a legend.

Cartier leans forward slightly.

CARTIER

Not a legend. It is real. You only need to believe.

Isa closes his hand gently around the pearl. Protecting it. Places the chain back in the box with great care.

SHEIKH ISA

Thank you, my friend.

Cartier bows his head.

CARTIER

Thank you. For teaching me where beauty begins.

128 INT. WORKER'S SHACK/JABAL AL-DUKHAN - OIL FIELD - DAWN

128

Holmes (60s) sleeps exhausted at a rough desk inside a workers' shack. His desk cluttered with maps, drilling records, failed samples, broken pencils.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
And then, one day, the earth
answered.

Outside, the rig groans. Then a voice yells -

WORKER (O.S.)
Mr Holmes!

Holmes jolts awake.

WORKER (CONT'D)
Mr Holmes!

Holmes runs outside.

129 **EXT. JABAL AL-DUKHAN/WELL NUMBER 1 - CONTINUOUS**

129

The men are backing away from the well.

A low rumble from beneath the earth. The ground trembles.

A ROAR. OIL BURSTS SKYWARD. A black plume in the desert sky.

The workers erupt - shouting, laughing, dancing in the oil. Some fall to their knees. Some embrace.

Holmes stands in the spray, soaked. Overwhelmed with joy -

SUPER: JEBEL/JABAL AL-DUKHAN "MOUNTAIN OF SMOKE" 2 JUNE 1932

130 **EXT. DESERT ROAD - DAY**

130

Open-top limousines cut across the desert toward Jabal Al-Dukhan.

Isa (80s) rides in the first car with HAYA, AISHA, and HAMAD.

Behind them: family, advisers, guards.

131 **EXT. JABAL AL-DUKHAN - OIL FIELD - DAY**

131

The cars arrive.

Isa steps out slowly. Haya follows. Then Aisha. Hamad.

Before them: the wellhead, the machinery, men blackened with oil, the desert transformed by a force no one can yet measure.

Holmes approaches, still stained from the strike.

He holds out a small glass vial of crude oil.

HOLMES

I refused to take no for an answer,
Your Honour.

Isa takes the vial - studies the dark liquid inside.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

For generations, we had taken our
treasure from the sea.

Isa looks from the vial to the gushing well.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

Now the fire beneath us had risen.

Haya & Hamad watch the plume with quiet astonishment. Aisha
watches Isa.

Isa's eyes are fixed on the well - not triumph, but awe.

132 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / STUDY - DAY**

132

The black pearl sits on Isa's desk. Beside it now: the vial of
dark oil.

Two small objects. Two eras.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

The pearl had fed us. The oil would
change us.

133 **EXT. BAHRAIN SHORE - MORNING**

133

Cannon fire rolls across the water.

The majestic ship HMS LUPIN enters the bay. Flags snap in the
wind.

134 **EXT. MANAMA - PUBLIC SPACE - DAY**

134

The whole of Bahrain seems to have gathered.

Drums. Rifles raised. Men cheering. Women singing. Children
running between robes and banners.

KING AL-SA'UD stands before Sheikh Isa and Sheikh Hamad. He
presents Hamad with a sword.

KING AL-SA'UD

Congratulations to you both.

The crowd cheer.

135 **EXT. STREETS OF MANAMA - DAY**

135

ZALAIKHA leads a group of women in a song of jubilation.

Haya stands with Aisha near Isa, both moved in different ways.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)

My father had dreamed that Bahrain
might stand on more than pearl and
tide.

SHEIKH HAMAD

May we prove worthy of what lies
beneath us.

SHEIKHA AISHA

Alhamdulillah.

Haya looks at Isa.

HAYA

He would have seen this in you.

SHEIKHA AISHA

Your father's dream has been
fulfilled.

He looks toward the horizon – the sea beyond the city, the twin minarets of Al-Khamis Mosque standing like witnesses.

SHEIKH ISA

It has begun.
(a beat)
Alhamdulillah.

The sound rises around him –

CROWD

Sheikh Isa! Sheikh Isa!

The chant grows.

CROWD (CONT'D)

Hakim! Hakim!

Haya and Aisha stand beside him as the chant rises over Manama.

136 **INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / SHEIKH ISA'S PRAYER ROOM - 1932** 136

The room is quiet now. Noura sits beside her grandfather. The story has changed her.

NOURA

The oil...

(a beat)

It was not the dream. Was it,
Grandfather?

Isa looks at her. A faint smile.

SHEIKH ISA

I told you that you would not need to
guess.

Noura thinks.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

So tell me.

NOURA

It was all of it. The pirates leaving.
The pearls. The schools. The
hospitals. And the oil.

SHEIKH ISA

Yes. All of it.

(a beat)

And none of it.

Noura waits.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

It was what I promised my father when
he lay dying on the battlefield.

137 **FLASHBACK - EXT. EAST RIFFA - BATTLEFIELD - DAY** 137

Young Isa kneels over SHEIKH ALI. Blood. Dust. The ruined sound of battle fading around them.

YOUNG ISA

I promise, Father.

Ali's hand grips Isa's.

YOUNG ISA (CONT'D)

I promise you.

Ali smiles. His hand releases. He is gone.

138 INT. ROYAL RESIDENCE / SHEIKH ISA'S PRAYER ROOM - 1932 - RESUME

Noura understands.

NOURA

It was your promise.

Isa nods.

SHEIKH ISA

Yes.

(a beat)

The promise we make to those who came
before us. To carry their love to
those who come after.

Noura looks at him, deeply moved. Isa sees the tears in her eyes
and gently saves her from them.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

But I have kept you from your friends.

NOURA

I do not mind.

SHEIKH ISA

Go. Let your grandfather have a moment
to pray and give thanks.

Noura rises.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

Thank you, Noura.

NOURA

I've done nothing to thank me for.

SHEIKH ISA

You were here. You held my hand. You
listened. That is enough.

She hesitates, wanting to say more.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)

(he smiles)

Go on.

She smiles also, through her tears and heads for the door.

Isa watches her go. He turns toward the qibla. Slowly, with great
effort and dignity, he begins to pray.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
Allah Akbar.
(bows his head.)
O Allah...

He lowers himself into sujood, forehead touching the prayer mat.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
Subhana rabbi al-a'la.

His voice is faint now. At the door, Noura pauses. Something makes her look back. Isa rises slowly to sit. His hands lift in dua.

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
(his breathing shallows)
Rabbana taqabbal minna... wa min
sha'bina.

His hands remain raised a moment longer. Then lower. He leans forward again into prostration. A final whisper:

SHEIKH ISA (CONT'D)
La ilaha illa Allah...

He falls forward onto the floor.

NOURA
Grandfather?

Noura stares. A terrible silence.

NOURA (CONT'D)
(rushing to him)
Grandfather!

Noura kneels beside him, she reaches out, almost frightened to touch him. Takes his hand, gently holds it.

NOURA (CONT'D)
Grandfather, I am still here.

Servants rush in - hover at the door, unsure what can be done.

Then Hamad enters, moves past them.

He sees his father lying still. The world falls out from beneath him. He runs forward, drops to his knees beside Isa.

He bends, touching his forehead to Isa's. He starts to cry.

DRIFT AWAY away from them... Out through the carved window... Out over Manama. The rooftops. The minarets. The harbour.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
May God bless you, O Bahrain.
May your people be embraced in
peace. May your shores be gentle,
your gardens fertile, your children
noble.

CONTINUE TO PULL BACK over the sea - Manama opens beneath us in
all its hard-won life.

SHEIKH ISA (V.O.)
If this land has spoken at last, let
its blessing belong to the future.
Not to my name. Not to my house. To
its people. To its children. To those
I will never meet.

The land rests between sea and sky.

CUT TO BLACK.

END CREDITS.